

MOUNTAIN BIKING IN BRASÍLIA

— THE ULTIMATE GUIDE —



ANDRÉ RAW

Mountain Biking in Brasília

The Ultimate Guide

By André Raw

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RED DIRT & BIG SKIES

Mountain Biking in Brasília — A Rider's Guide to Brazil's Hidden Trail Capital

By André Raw

Dedication

To every rider who's ever crested a hill in the cerrado and felt the warm wind hit their face. To the Rebas do Cerrado crew who maintain trails with machetes and love. To the capybaras who judge us silently from the riverbanks. And to Brasília — the city that nobody expects to fall in love with, but everyone does.

This one's for you, pedal heads.

A Note from the Author

I never planned to write a book about mountain biking.

I planned to ride. That was the whole idea when I came back to Brazil after sixteen years in the United States — eight in Massachusetts, eight in Florida. I came home to Brasília, moved to Grande Colorado on the edge of the Fercal region, and bought a bike. A simple plan.

But the cerrado had other ideas.

From my first ride through the red dirt trails behind my house, I was hooked. Not just on the riding — on the everything. The sky here does things I've never seen anywhere else on Earth. The trails twist through landscapes that look like another planet. The community rides with a warmth and alegria (joy) that makes you forget you just climbed 800 meters of elevation.

Within a year, I'd ridden hundreds of kilometers of trails I didn't even know existed when I moved here. I'd discovered waterfalls hidden in limestone canyons, raced through the FLONA (Floresta Nacional de Brasília) at dawn, and shared café com pão de queijo (coffee with cheese bread) at trailheads with riders who became lifelong friends.

And I kept thinking: Why doesn't anyone know about this?

Brasília has over 400 kilometers of mapped mountain biking trails. It has the largest signposted MTB trail system in a conservation unit in all of Brazil. It has a 136-kilometer circuit — the largest MTB circuit in the country. It has trails for absolute beginners and trails that would make World Cup riders sweat. It has waterfalls you can ride to, cerrado wildlife you'll never forget, and a community that will welcome you like family.



The next generation of Brasília riders — singletrack through cerrado wildflowers
with the Digital TV Tower watching over

Yet when you search for "mountain biking in Brazil," you get...
Florianópolis. Maybe São Paulo. Nobody talks about Brasília.

This book changes that.

Whether you're an international traveler looking for your next
adventure, an expat who just landed in the Planalto Central and doesn't
know where to start, a Brazilian rider from another state curious about
what the capital has to offer, or a complete beginner who's never thrown
a leg over a mountain bike — this book is for you.

I'll take you trail by trail, season by season, from gear selection to race
day. I'll share the mistakes I made so you don't have to. I'll introduce you
to the places and people that make Brasília's MTB scene unlike anything
else in the world.

All you have to do is turn the page.

Bora pedalar! (Let's ride!)

— André Raw

Grande Colorado, Brasília DF

2026

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Part I: Welcome to Brasília

Chapter 1: Why Brasília Is an MTB Paradise

There's a moment on every ride that makes everything worth it.

For me, it happens about forty minutes into the climb out of Fercal, when the trail crests a limestone ridge and the entire Planalto Central opens up below you. The cerrado stretches in every direction — a rolling sea of twisted trees, golden grasses, and red earth that seems to pulse with heat. In the distance, the white curve of a Niemeyer building catches the light. Above it all, that sky. That impossible, enormous, blazing Brasília sky.

You're standing over your bike, chest heaving, sweat dripping off your chin onto the red dirt, and you think: How does nobody know about this place?

That question is why this book exists.

The Secret Capital

Let me tell you what most people think they know about Brasília.

They know it's the capital of Brazil. They know it was built in the 1960s, carved out of nothing in the middle of the cerrado (savanna), designed by Oscar Niemeyer and Lúcio Costa to look like an airplane from the air. They know it's full of politicians and bureaucrats. They've maybe seen a photo of the Catedral Metropolitana or the twin towers of the Congresso Nacional.

And that's where their knowledge ends.

What they don't know — what I didn't know, even as a Brazilian who grew up nearby — is that Brasília sits at the center of one of the most extraordinary natural landscapes in South America. The Distrito Federal (Federal District) is 5,802 square kilometers of rolling plateau, limestone valleys, cerrado forest, crystal-clear streams, and dramatic escarpments. It sits at roughly 1,100 meters of elevation, giving it a climate that riders from Europe or North America would kill for: warm days, cool mornings,

low humidity in the dry season, and none of the suffocating heat of the coast.

And someone — actually, a lot of someones — has been quietly building a world-class trail network through all of it.

The Numbers Don't Lie

Let me throw some numbers at you, because they still blow my mind:

- **400+ kilometers** of mapped and maintained mountain biking trails in the Distrito Federal, forming the Caminhos do Planalto Central (Paths of the Central Plateau) network
- **136 kilometers** in a single connected circuit — the **largest MTB circuit in Brazil** — linking FLONA, Trilha União, and Serrinha do Paranoá
- **7 signposted routes** in FLONA alone, ranging from 5 to 44 kilometers, making it the **largest signalized MTB trail in a conservation unit in the country**
- Trails ranging from flat, smooth estradas de terra (dirt roads) suitable for your first-ever ride to 100-kilometer death marches with nearly 2,000 meters of climbing
- Dozens of waterfalls reachable by bike
- An active community of thousands of riders with organized group rides happening multiple times per week

When I first discovered these numbers after moving back to Brazil, I thought there must be some mistake. How could a city known for concrete and politics have this kind of trail infrastructure?

Then I started riding. And I stopped questioning.

My Story

I should probably explain how a guy who spent sixteen years in the United States ended up writing a mountain biking guide to Brasília.

I grew up in Brazil but left in my twenties for the US. Eight years in Massachusetts — beautiful state, terrible winters. Eight years in Florida — beautiful beaches, terrible flatness. I rode bikes in both places, but there was always something missing. In Massachusetts, the season was too short. In Florida, there were no hills to speak of. I'd drive two hours to find a proper trail and be done in forty-five minutes.

When I decided to come back to Brazil, I chose Brasília for practical reasons. Family connections, job opportunities, the lower cost of living compared to São Paulo. I found a house in Grande Colorado, a condomínio (gated community) on the edge of the Fercal region, and settled in.

Fercal turned out to be the greatest accident of my life.

This region, just northwest of Brasília's urban core, is where the city meets the wild. My backyard is essentially the gateway to a trail system that stretches for hundreds of kilometers. Within a twenty-minute ride from my front door, I can be on singletrack that feels like it belongs in British Columbia or Moab. Within forty minutes, I can be at a waterfall. Within an hour, I can be deep in the FLONA, surrounded by nothing but cerrado, birdsong, and the sound of my tires on packed red earth.

I started riding casually. A few times a week, 15-20 kilometers, just getting my legs back. Within months, I was doing 40-kilometer rides with 800+ meters of climbing. Within a year, I was signing up for races I had no business entering.

André's Tip: If you're moving to Brasília and choosing where to live, consider the northern regions — Sobradinho, Grande

Colorado, Fercal, or Lago Norte. You'll be closer to the best trail access points and can literally ride from your doorstep to world-class singletrack.

What Makes Brasília Different

I've ridden in a lot of places. The rocky, rooty trails of New England. The sandy flatness of Florida. The famous bike parks of Europe (on vacation, wishing I could afford to stay). But Brasília has a combination of factors that I haven't found anywhere else:

The Terrain

The Planalto Central sits on a bed of ancient geology — limestone karst, laterite deposits, quartzite outcrops. This creates an incredible variety of trail surfaces. In a single ride, you might go from packed red clay to loose rocky descents to sandy creek crossings to smooth singletrack through gallery forest. The constant elevation changes — Brasília ranges from about 750 to 1,350 meters — mean you're always climbing or descending. Flat is rare. Your legs know it.

The Climate

Brasília has two seasons, and both are excellent for riding. The seca (dry season), from May to September, is the classic riding season: sunny skies, temperatures between 18-28°C, virtually zero rain, and a golden light that makes everything look like a film set. The trails are hard-packed, fast, and dusty. The only downside is the dry air — humidity can drop below 15%, which means hydration is not optional, it's survival.

The chuvas (rainy season), from October to April, transforms the cerrado into an explosion of green. The trails get muddy, the creek crossings get deeper, and everything is more challenging. But it's also more beautiful.

The ipê trees bloom in spectacular yellows and purples. The waterfalls are at full force. And if you time it right, you can ride through a dramatic afternoon thunderstorm and emerge into a sunset that'll make you pull over and just stare.

The Infrastructure

This is where Brasília really surprises people. This isn't some random collection of social trails hacked through the bush. The DF has a legitimate, organized, maintained trail network. Rebas do Cerrado, the primary trail stewardship organization, has spent years mapping, signing, and maintaining trails. The FLONA trails are professionally signposted with difficulty ratings, distance markers, and QR codes for GPS tracks. The Caminhos do Planalto Central project has mapped three arcs of trails totaling over 400 kilometers, with the goal of connecting the entire Federal District by bike.

In 2025, the Instituto Urucua published *Trilhando o Caminho da Beleza e do Turismo Local* — a dedicated guide to Fercal's trails, with 2,500 copies distributed. Wikiloc has thousands of GPS tracks uploaded by local riders. This is not a frontier discovery mission; this is a mature, mapped, documented trail system that happens to be completely unknown outside of Brazil.

The Community

I saved the best for last.

Brazilian cycling culture is something special. There's a word — *pedalada* — that means both "ride" and the act of pedaling, and it carries with it an entire culture of shared experience. When you join a group ride in Brasília, you're not just riding bikes. You're sharing stories, jokes, rapadura (sugarcane candy) at rest stops, cold guaraná at the trailhead after. You're getting invited to someone's churrasco (barbecue) next

weekend. You're being given a trail name and a WhatsApp invite before you even finish your first loop.

The community here is overwhelmingly welcoming to newcomers. It doesn't matter if you're on a R\$2,000 entry-level hardtail or a R\$50,000 carbon full-suspension rocket ship. If you show up at a trailhead with a smile and a willingness to suffer a little, you're family.

André's Tip: The fastest way to plug into Brasília's MTB community is to join a Rebas do Cerrado group ride. Check their website (pedal.rebas.com.br) and social media for schedules. Just show up — they expect new faces, and someone will adopt you before the first kilometer.

Who This Book Is For

This book is for four kinds of people:

The International Traveler. You're visiting Brasília — maybe for work, maybe because you're exploring Brazil — and you want more than museums and restaurants. You want dirt under your tires. I'll show you how to get it, even if you only have a day or two.

The Expat. You just moved to Brasília, you're overwhelmed by the vastness of this city, and you need something to keep you sane. Mountain biking saved me. It'll save you too. This book will get you from "I don't even own a bike" to "I just finished a 50K race" faster than you think.

The Visiting Brazilian Rider. You're from São Paulo, Rio, BH, wherever, and you've heard rumors about Brasília's trails. The rumors are true. All of them. This book will help you plan an epic trip.

The Curious Beginner. You've never mountain biked in your life, but something about the idea appeals to you. Maybe it's the adventure. Maybe it's the fitness. Maybe you just saw a cool photo on Instagram. Whatever it is, start here. Chapter 3 is literally written for you.

How to Use This Book

This book is designed to work however you need it.

If you're a complete beginner, start at Chapter 3 and work forward. I'll walk you through buying a bike, gearing up, getting fit, and choosing your first trail.

If you're an experienced rider who just wants trail beta, skip straight to Part III (Chapters 6-10). Every trail includes GPS coordinates, distance, elevation, difficulty ratings, and my honest assessment of what you'll find out there.

If you're here for the culture and the community, Part IV (Chapters 11-13) is where the magic is.

And if you just want to read a good adventure story about an unexpected place, read it cover to cover. I promise you'll want to book a flight by the end.

A Love Letter

I want to be honest with you. This book is biased. Wildly, unapologetically biased.

I love this city. I love its weird spaceship architecture. I love its absurd sky. I love that you can ride from a government ministry to a waterfall in under an hour. I love the red dirt that permanently stains everything I own. I love the way the cerrado smells after rain — like earth and honey and something ancient you can't name.

I love the riders here. The weekend warriors who show up before dawn. The velhos (old guys) who drop me on every climb. The women's groups who are growing the sport faster than anyone. The kids doing wheelies on the bike paths. All of them.

This is not an objective, clinical trail guide. This is a love letter to Brasília, written in red dirt and sweat and saudade (longing). It's personal. It's passionate. It's the book I wish someone had given me when I first arrived.

Let's ride.

Chapter 2: Brasília Beyond Politics — The Cerrado, the Sky, the Architecture



The cerrado hills stretching endlessly from a trail overlook —
Brasília beyond politics

Before we talk about bikes, we need to talk about the place.

Because Brasília isn't just a city where you happen to mountain bike. Brasília is the experience. The landscape shapes every ride. The sky sets the mood. The architecture gives you landmarks when you're twenty kilometers deep and wondering if you took the right fork. The waterfalls give you a reason to keep going when your legs are begging you to stop.

If you want to understand why riding here is different from riding anywhere else on Earth, you need to understand this place. And I promise you, by the end of this chapter, you'll understand why I can't shut up about it.

The Cerrado: World's Most Biodiverse Savanna

Let's start with the ground you'll be riding on.

The cerrado is Brazil's second-largest biome, covering about 2 million square kilometers — roughly 23% of the country. It's the most biodiverse tropical savanna on the planet, home to over 12,000 plant species, 200 species of mammals, 800 species of birds, and countless reptiles, amphibians, and insects. More than a third of its plant species exist nowhere else on Earth.

But here's the thing: the cerrado doesn't look like what most people picture when they think "savanna." Forget the flat, open grasslands of the African Serengeti. The cerrado is a dense, twisted, ancient landscape — a puzzle of different vegetation types that shift as you ride through them.



Campo sujo — the cerrado's 'messy living room' of scattered trees and golden grasses

On a single ride, you might pass through:

Campo limpo (clean field) — Open grassland with low scrub, often on hilltops and ridges. This is where you get the big views and the fast, rolling sections that make you feel like you're flying.

Campo sujo (dirty field) — Grassland with scattered small trees and shrubs. The "messy living room" of the cerrado.

Cerrado stricto sensu — The classic cerrado landscape: twisted trees with thick, fire-resistant bark growing from red laterite soil, interspersed with grasses and wildflowers. This is the scenery you'll see most often on Brasília's trails.

Cerradão — Dense cerrado forest, almost closed-canopy, with taller trees and deep shade. Riding through cerradão on a hot afternoon is like entering a natural air conditioning system.

Mata de galeria (gallery forest) — Lush, green forest that lines the streams and rivers, creating tunnels of shade and cool air. These are

some of the most magical sections of any ride: you'll hear the water before you see it, the temperature drops noticeably, and the trail often crosses the stream on smooth rocks or small wooden bridges.

Veredas — Marshy palm groves dominated by the iconic buriti palm. These are wetland areas you'll usually ride around rather than through, but they're stunning to look at, especially at sunset when the palms are silhouetted against the sky.

André's Tip: Learn to read the vegetation as you ride. When you see gallery forest ahead, there's a stream crossing coming. When the trees thin out to campo limpo, you're approaching a ridge — get ready for views and possibly wind. The cerrado tells you what's next if you pay attention.

Wildlife You'll Actually See

Riding in the cerrado means riding with wildlife. Not in a zoo, not from a car — right there on the trail with you.

The most common sighting is the **capybara** (cavivara). These oversized, absurdly calm rodents — the world's largest, weighing up to 80 kg — hang out near water and will watch you ride past with an expression of supreme indifference. They are Brasília's unofficial mascot, and at least one major race is named after them (Desafio das Capivaras).



The unofficial mascot of Brasília's trails — a capybara showing its trademark supreme indifference

You'll see **toucans** (tucanos) in the gallery forests — the iconic tucano-toco with its enormous orange bill is common. **Macaws** (araras) wheel overhead in pairs, their blue-and-gold plumage flashing in the sun. **Seriemas** — long-legged birds that look like they were designed by committee — run alongside the trails and occasionally startle you with their otherworldly screaming call.

If you're very lucky and very quiet, you might spot a **lobo-guará** (maned wolf) — the cerrado's most iconic predator, a long-legged, red-furred canid that looks like a fox on stilts. I've seen them twice in three years of riding, both times at dawn on trails near FLONA.

And then there are the creatures you need to watch out for. **Rattlesnakes** (cascavéis) are present in dry, rocky areas during the dry season — they're not aggressive but don't step on one. **Ticks** (carrapatos) are a real issue, especially in tall grass during the rainy season. I'll cover how to deal with them in Chapter 5.

The Sky: Brasília's Greatest Show

Ask anyone who lives in Brasília what they love most about the city, and at least half will say the sky.

It's not an exaggeration. Brasília's sky is famous throughout Brazil, and once you've seen it, you'll understand why.

The combination of factors is unique: the city sits at 1,100+ meters of elevation on a vast, open plateau with minimal light pollution outside the urban core. The Planalto Central has enormous skies — there are no mountains or tall buildings blocking the view from horizon to horizon. The cerrado's dust, combined with the atmospheric conditions of the central plateau, creates sunsets and sunrises that routinely look digitally enhanced.



Sempre-vivas — the eternal flowers of the cerrado, blooming in
defiance of the dry season

During the dry season, the dust in the air scatters light in ways that turn the entire western sky into a canvas of orange, pink, purple, and gold. These aren't occasional spectacles — they happen almost every single evening from May to September. Riders time their afternoon rides specifically to be on a high point at golden hour, the hour before sunset when the light transforms the cerrado into something from a painting.

During the rainy season, the sky puts on a different show. Massive cumulonimbus clouds build during the afternoon, towering to 15,000 meters or more, creating dramatic lightning displays and short, intense downpours. The light between storms is extraordinary — shafts of gold breaking through dark clouds, double rainbows, that electric feeling in the air.

André's Tip: Plan at least one ride to finish at sunset on a high viewpoint. The trail from FLONA's Rota 7 has a section that faces west with an unobstructed view — it's my favorite spot in all of Brasília. Trust me on this one.

Oscar Niemeyer's Playground

You cannot separate Brasília from its architecture. The city is its architecture.

Designed by Oscar Niemeyer (buildings) and Lúcio Costa (urban plan), Brasília was built from scratch between 1956 and 1960 as Brazil's new capital. It was meant to be a monument to the future — and sixty-plus years later, it still looks like one.

For a mountain biker, Niemeyer's buildings serve as more than cultural landmarks. They're navigation aids, trail markers, and the reason your ride photos look incredible.



The iconic JK Bridge crossing Lago Paranoá — Brasília's architectural marvel illuminated at night

Here are the landmarks you'll see from the trails:

Catedral Metropolitana — Niemeyer's masterpiece. Sixteen curved concrete columns rising from the ground like hands reaching for heaven. Visible from many trails south and east of the city center. It's particularly stunning at night when it's illuminated.

Congresso Nacional — The twin towers flanked by the dome (Senate) and the bowl (Chamber of Deputies). The most recognized symbol of Brasília, visible from trails to the east, and a perfect orientation landmark when you're riding the Paranoá area.

Palácio da Alvorada — The president's official residence, set on the shore of Lago Paranoá. The columns are some of Niemeyer's most beautiful work. You'll see it on rides along the lake's eastern shore.

Ponte JK — Not Niemeyer, but an architectural icon: the Juscelino Kubitschek Bridge crosses Lago Paranoá with three asymmetric arches that look like a giant skipping stones across the water. You can ride across it (there's a bike lane) for one of the best views in the city.

TV Tower (Torre de TV) — A 224-meter steel tower in the center of the city's Eixo Monumental. Visible from almost everywhere, it's the ultimate "am I going the right direction?" landmark.

The remarkable thing about riding in Brasília is the constant juxtaposition. One moment you're deep in raw cerrado, feeling like you're a hundred kilometers from civilization. Then you crest a ridge and there's the Congresso Nacional, gleaming white against the blue sky, reminding you that you're fifteen minutes from a shopping mall. It's surreal, and it never gets old.

The Waterfalls: Your Ride's Reward

If the cerrado is the stage and the sky is the lighting, the waterfalls are the encore.

The Distrito Federal and its immediate surroundings are blessed with an extraordinary concentration of waterfalls, many of them reachable by bike. The limestone geology of the region creates dramatic drops and crystal-clear pools that are perfect for a post-ride swim.

Here are the waterfalls every rider should know:

Poço Azul — The "Blue Pool," located in Brazlândia. A stunning blue pool at the base of a small waterfall, surrounded by forest. Reachable by a moderate trail ride from several trailheads. The color is extraordinary and yes, it really is that blue.

Cachoeira do Tororó — In the Fercal region, relatively close to my home. A beautiful multi-tiered waterfall in a limestone canyon. The ride

in is moderate and scenic, through classic cerrado with gallery forest sections.

Cachoeira Três Quedas — "Three Falls," accessible via the Trilha Olaria (41 km). Located at Fazenda Xanguí, there's a small entry fee (R\$10 per bike), but it's worth every centavo. Three distinct cascades, swimming pools, and a grassy area to rest.

Cachoeira do Monjolo — Near the Fercal/Sobradinho area. A popular post-ride stop with a large pool and easy access from several trail systems.

Mumunhas Waterfall — A hidden gem in the FLONA area that requires a bit of trail knowledge to find. Ask local riders — they'll happily show you the way.

André's Tip: Always bring a small dry bag on waterfall rides. Nothing ruins a ride like a waterlogged phone. I use a simple roll-top dry bag that fits in my pack — it's saved my electronics more times than I can count.

Seasons: Two Worlds, One City

Brasília's two seasons create fundamentally different riding experiences. Understanding them is crucial for planning your trip or your riding year.

The Dry Season — A Seca (May to September)

This is prime riding season, and it's spectacular.

The rain stops almost completely. Days are sunny, warm (22-28°C), and dry. Nights are cool (12-18°C), sometimes genuinely cold by Brazilian

standards. The humidity plummets — in July and August, it can drop below 12%, which is drier than many deserts.

The trails transform. Red laterite dirt bakes hard and fast. Dust clouds follow every rider. The cerrado turns gold and brown, the grasses dry to a crackling whisper, and the ipê trees bloom in shocking bursts of yellow, white, pink, and purple against the parched landscape. It's austere and beautiful.

The advantages for riding are enormous: predictable weather, fast trail conditions, minimal mud, and those legendary sunsets every single evening. The disadvantage is the dryness — your lips will crack, your nose will bleed, your skin will beg for moisture. Hydration becomes critical. I carry a minimum of 3 liters for any ride over 20 kilometers in the dry season.

The Rainy Season — As Chuvas (October to April)

When the rains come, the cerrado explodes.

Almost overnight, the brown landscape turns impossibly green. Wildflowers carpet the campo limpo. The streams and waterfalls that were dry trickles in September become roaring torrents by November. The air fills with the smell of wet earth, and the sunsets — if anything — become even more dramatic as storms build and break across the plateau.

Riding in the rainy season is a completely different sport. Trails that were hard-packed in July become muddy slip-and-slides by December. Creek crossings that were ankle-deep become waist-deep. Your bike will gain five kilograms of mud. Your clothes will never be white again.

But it's also incredible. The green cerrado is achingly beautiful. The cooler temperatures during rain make climbing easier. The trails are quieter — fair-weather riders stay home, so you get the wilderness to

yourself. And the satisfaction of completing a muddy, technical ride in the rain is something you can't get in the dry season.

The pattern is generally predictable: mornings are clear, clouds build through midday, and rain arrives in the afternoon — typically between 14:00 and 18:00, often as dramatic thunderstorms that dump huge amounts of water in a short time and then clear to reveal stunning skies. Smart riders plan their rides for early morning in the rainy season, finishing before the afternoon storms roll in.

André's Tip: In the rainy season, always start your ride by 6:00 AM if possible. You'll get the best conditions, avoid the afternoon storms, and see the cerrado at its most beautiful with the morning dew still on the flowers. Plus, you'll be done and having lunch while the thunder rolls in. Win-win.

The City That Surprises

People come to Brasília for politics and leave talking about nature. They come for a conference and start looking at real estate. They come for a weekend and plan their return before the plane takes off.

This city surprises everyone.

It surprised me. I moved here thinking it would be practical, convenient, a good base. I didn't expect to fall in love. I didn't expect to find a trail system that rivals anything I've ridden in the Americas. I didn't expect to stand on a limestone ridge at 6:30 PM watching the sky catch fire and feel, for the first time in years, like I was exactly where I was supposed to be.

Brasília is not a city you understand from photos or Wikipedia articles. You have to breathe the dry air, feel the red dirt between your fingers, hear the seriemas screaming at dawn. You have to ride it.

So let's get you ready to ride.

Part II: Getting Started

Chapter 3: Mountain Biking

Basics — Choosing Your Bike



A Specialized mountain bike ready for action on a cerrado forest trail

You've seen the photos. You've read about the trails, the waterfalls, the sunsets. You're in. You want to ride Brasília.

Now the question that stops most people cold: Which bike do I buy?

I'm going to make this simple. Not because the topic isn't complex — entire books have been written about bike selection — but because overthinking this decision is the number one thing that keeps people from actually riding. I've watched friends spend six months researching bikes while I put 2,000 kilometers on my "good enough" rig. Don't be that person.

Let's get you on a bike.

Mountain Bike Categories: What's What

The mountain bike world has a taxonomy that can feel like it was designed by a committee of engineers who hate marketing people. Let me cut through it.

Hardtail

A hardtail has front suspension (a shock-absorbing fork) but no rear suspension. The rear triangle is rigid — "hard tail," get it?

Why you want one:

- Lighter than full-suspension bikes at the same price point
- More efficient on climbs — your pedaling energy goes into forward motion, not bouncing the rear shock
- Simpler mechanics = less maintenance = fewer things to break
- Forces you to develop better technical skills (you can't rely on the rear suspension to smooth out your mistakes)
- Significantly cheaper than comparable full-suspension bikes

Why you might not:

- Less comfortable on rough, rocky terrain
- Less traction on loose descents
- Your body absorbs all the impacts the rear wheel hits
- On long, rough rides, fatigue accumulates faster

Best for: Beginners, budget-conscious riders, fitness-focused riders, XC racers, riders on smoother trails

Full-Suspension

A full-suspension bike (often called "full-sus") has both front suspension and a rear shock, connected through a linkage system. Both wheels can absorb impacts independently.

Why you want one:

- Dramatically more comfortable on rough terrain
- Better traction on loose or rocky descents
- More forgiving of mistakes — the bike works with you
- Less physical fatigue on long, technical rides
- More capable on advanced trails

Why you might not:

- Heavier
- More expensive (significantly)
- More complex maintenance
- Rear suspension absorbs some pedaling energy ("pedal bob"), though modern designs minimize this
- Can mask poor technique — you don't learn to read terrain as well

Best for: Intermediate to advanced riders, rough/rocky terrain, enduro and trail riding, riders who prioritize comfort and descending

Gravel/Adventure Bikes

These aren't traditional mountain bikes, but they deserve mention because they're increasingly popular in Brasília. Gravel bikes are essentially road bikes with wider tires, disc brakes, and a more relaxed geometry. They're designed for estradas de terra (dirt roads), fire roads, and smooth trails.

Why you might want one: If your riding will be primarily on Brasília's many dirt roads and smooth double-track rather than technical singletrack, a gravel bike is faster and more efficient. Some of the longer routes in the Caminhos do Planalto Central network include significant sections that are perfect for gravel bikes.

Why you might not: They're not designed for technical singletrack. Take a gravel bike on a rocky FLONA trail and you'll have a bad time.

André's Tip: For 90% of riders coming to Brasília, a **hardtail** is the right first bike. The majority of trails here — especially beginner and intermediate ones — ride beautifully on a good hardtail. I rode my first year entirely on a hardtail and had the time of my life. Save your money for full-suspension once you know you're committed and you know what kind of riding you love.

Understanding Suspension Travel

Suspension travel is measured in millimeters (mm) and tells you how much the fork or shock can compress. More travel = more cushioning = more capability on rough terrain, but also more weight and less pedaling efficiency.

Here's a rough guide for Brasília's trails:

Travel	Category	Best For
80-100mm	Cross-Country (XC)	Smooth trails, dirt roads, racing, fitness rides
100-120mm	Trail	All-around riding, most of Brasília's trails
130-150mm	All-Mountain/Enduro	Rough, technical trails, big descents
160mm+	Enduro/Downhill	Extreme terrain, bike parks

For Brasília, **100-130mm** is the sweet spot. Most trails here have a mix of climbing and descending with moderate technical features. A 120mm trail bike is the Swiss Army knife — it'll handle everything from a gentle estrada de terra to a rocky FLONA descent without being overgunned for the terrain.

Wheel Size

Mountain bikes come in three main wheel sizes, and this matters more than you might think:

29" (twenty-niners): The current standard. Larger wheels roll over obstacles more easily, maintain momentum better, and provide more stability at speed. The vast majority of modern mountain bikes come in 29". For Brasília's rolling terrain with its roots, rocks, and creek crossings, 29" is ideal.

27.5" (also called 650b): Slightly smaller, slightly more nimble. Popular for riders under 170cm tall, or those who prioritize quick handling over rolling speed. You'll see some riders on 27.5" in Brasília, and it works fine.

Mullet (29" front, 27.5" rear): A hybrid setup that combines the rollover capability of a 29" front wheel with the agility of a 27.5" rear. Increasingly popular, especially on enduro-style bikes.

My recommendation: **Go 29"**. Unless you're significantly shorter than average or have a specific reason to prefer smaller wheels, the 29" standard is the right choice for Brasília's terrain.

What to Spend: Budget Reality

Let's talk money. I'll use Brazilian Reais (R\$) since that's what you'll be shopping in if you're buying in Brasília, with approximate USD equivalents.

Entry Level: R\$2,000-5,000 (US\$400-1,000)

What you get: An aluminum hardtail with basic suspension, mechanical disc brakes, and entry-level components. Brands like GTS, Absolute, Oggi, and Rava offer solid options at this level.

Honest assessment: These bikes will get you on the trails. They won't be light, the suspension won't be plush, and the components will need replacing sooner. But they work. I know riders putting 100+ km per week on bikes at this price point.

Mid-Range: R\$5,000-12,000 (US\$1,000-2,500)

What you get: An aluminum or carbon hardtail with better suspension (air forks), hydraulic disc brakes, and reliable components. Or an entry-level full-suspension. This is where the riding experience starts to feel genuinely good. Brands like Sense, Caloi, Audax, and Cannondale Trail series live here.

Honest assessment: This is the sweet spot for most riders. A R\$8,000 hardtail from a reputable brand will handle 95% of Brasília's trails with aplomb and last for years with basic maintenance.

High-End: R\$12,000-30,000+ (US\$2,500-6,000+)

What you get: Carbon frames, premium suspension (Fox, RockShox), top-tier drivetrains (Shimano Deore XT/XTR, SRAM GX/X01), and full-suspension platforms that are a revelation on rough terrain. Brands like Specialized, Trek, Scott, and Canyon at this level.

Honest assessment: These bikes are incredible, and if you have the budget, you'll love every ride. But don't let the perfect be the enemy of the good. A R\$30,000 bike will not make you three times the rider a R\$10,000 bike will. Legs are legs.

André's Tip: If you're visiting Brasília and don't want to buy, several shops offer **bike rental** for trail riding. Brasília Bike Camp and some local shops can set you up with a quality rental for R\$100-250 per day. Just call ahead — supply is limited. Check with the LBS (local bike shop) near your accommodation.

Buying in Brasília

If you're buying a bike in Brasília, you have several options:

Local Bike Shops (LBS): Brasília has a healthy network of bike shops, particularly concentrated in the Asa Norte and Lago Sul areas. The advantage of an LBS is that you can test-ride, get fitted, and build a relationship with a mechanic. You'll pay slightly more than online, but the service is worth it.

Online Retailers: Sites like Netshoes, Bike Plus, and direct-from-manufacturer options (Sense, Oggi, Absolute) can save 10-20%. The tradeoff: no test ride, and assembly/setup is on you unless you pay a shop.

Used Market: OLX, Mercado Livre, and Facebook Marketplace have an active used bike market in Brasília. You can find serious deals — I've seen carbon full-suspension bikes that retail for R\$20,000+ going for R\$8,000-12,000 used. The risk: you need to know what you're looking at. Bring a knowledgeable friend or have a shop inspect the bike before you pay.

Bike Fit Matters

Whatever you buy, get it fitted. A bike that's the wrong size or poorly adjusted will turn every ride into a misery of sore knees, aching backs, and numb hands. Most shops in Brasília offer basic fitting when you purchase, and some offer professional bike fitting services (called bike fit) for R\$200-500.

The basics: when standing over the top tube, you should have 5-10cm of clearance. When seated with your heel on the pedal at the bottom of the stroke, your leg should be almost fully extended. When riding with the ball of your foot on the pedal, you should have a slight bend in the knee.

Electric Mountain Bikes (e-MTBs)

I can't write a bike chapter in 2026 without mentioning e-MTBs, because they're everywhere now.

Electric mountain bikes use a motor (usually mid-drive, mounted at the bottom bracket) to assist your pedaling. They don't ride themselves — you still have to pedal — but the motor multiplies your effort, making climbs easier and longer rides more accessible.

The case for e-MTBs in Brasília: The trails here involve a LOT of climbing. If you're not in peak fitness, an e-MTB can open up trails that would otherwise destroy you. They're also great for riders recovering from injuries, older riders who want to keep up with the group, and anyone who just wants to ride more and suffer less.

The case against: Purists will give you grief (ignore them). They're heavier — 20-25 kg vs 12-15 kg for a regular bike — which makes them harder to handle on technical sections. And they're expensive: a decent e-MTB starts at R\$15,000 and quickly escalates.

My take: No judgment. If an e-MTB gets you on the trails, it's a good bike. Just be aware that some organized rides and races separate e-MTB and traditional categories, and some trail groups have specific policies.

The Most Important Advice in This Chapter

Here it is, the thing I most want you to remember:

The best bike is the one you ride.

Not the one you research for six months. Not the one you save up for while your fitness deteriorates. Not the one that the forum says is "minimum" for real mountain biking. The one you actually throw a leg over and ride.

I started riding Brasília's trails on a R\$3,500 hardtail that a bike snob would have laughed at. I rode it for 2,000 kilometers. I rode it through FLONA, up Córrego do Ouro, through rainy-season mud and dry-season dust. I crashed it, fixed it, crashed it again, and loved every kilometer.

It wasn't the best bike. It was my bike, and it took me to places that changed my life.

Get a bike. Any bike. And start riding.

Chapter 4: Essential Gear — Everything You Need



Two bikes at a scenic overlook — geared up and ready for the
trails ahead

There's a rider I see sometimes at the FLONA trailhead. Full kit. Matching jersey and shorts. Carbon helmet with MIPS. Oakley Jawbreakers. Custom-painted titanium bottle cage. The works. He looks like he just walked off a World Cup course.

Then there's seu Marcos, who's been riding these trails for fifteen years. He wears a faded soccer jersey, cargo shorts, flip-flops replaced with ancient SPD sandals, and a helmet that might predate the city of Brasília itself. His bike weighs more than some small motorcycles.

Seu Marcos drops everybody on the climbs. Every time.

Gear matters. But not as much as the gear companies want you to think. What matters is having the **right** gear — the stuff that keeps you safe, comfortable, and capable on the trail. Not the most expensive, not the most Instagram-worthy. The right stuff.

This chapter covers everything you need, from essential to nice-to-have, with specific recommendations for Brasília's conditions.

Non-Negotiable: The Safety Essentials

Helmet

This is the one piece of gear where I'll be absolutely rigid: **you must wear a helmet**. Every ride. No exceptions.

Mountain biking involves rocks, trees, unexpected drops, loose gravel, and other riders. Falls happen to everyone — beginners and experts alike. I've crashed more times than I can count, and my helmet has saved me from serious injury at least twice.

What to look for:

- **MIPS or equivalent rotation protection** — This is a system that allows the helmet to rotate slightly on impact, reducing rotational forces on the brain. Worth the extra R\$100-200.
- **Good ventilation** — Brasília is hot. A helmet with poor ventilation will overheat you. Look for generous vents and internal channeling.
- **Proper fit** — The helmet should sit level on your head, covering your forehead, and should not move when you shake your head. If it rocks or slides, it's the wrong size.
- **Visor** — A visor protects from sun and low branches. All mountain bike-specific helmets have them.

Budget: R\$200-400 for a solid trail helmet. R\$400-800 for premium options with MIPS.

Full-face helmets: For advanced trails with significant drops and technical descents, a full-face helmet provides chin and jaw protection. Some riders use convertible helmets with removable chin bars — a good compromise if you ride varied terrain. Not necessary for most of Brasília's trails, but worth considering for places like the Córrego do Ouro descent.

André's Tip: Replace your helmet after any significant impact, even if it looks fine. The foam inside is designed to compress once — after that, it's not protecting you. Also replace every 3-5 years regardless, as materials degrade. I write the purchase date inside mine with a marker.

Eye Protection

Riding without eye protection in the cerrado is asking for trouble. Between the red dust of the dry season, the insects of the rainy season, and the constant risk of a branch to the face, your eyes need a shield.

Clear/photochromic lenses are the most versatile — they adjust to light conditions and work for both shady gallery forest and open campo limpo. If you can only bring one pair, make it photochromic.

Dark/mirrored lenses are great for the dry season's relentless sun but useless in shade or at dawn/dusk.

Budget: R\$50-100 for functional sports glasses. R\$300-800 for premium brands (Oakley, 100%). The expensive ones are nicer, but R\$50 glasses protect your eyes just as well.

Gloves

Full-finger gloves are essential for mountain biking. They protect your hands from blisters, branches, and road rash, and dramatically improve your grip on the handlebars when you're sweating — which, in Brasília, is always.

What to look for: Breathability is king. Brasília is too warm for heavy, padded downhill gloves on most rides. Go with lightweight, well-ventilated trail gloves with minimal padding and a good grip surface.

Budget: R\$50-150.

Comfort Gear: Making the Ride Enjoyable

Cycling Shorts (with Chamois)

The chamois (pronounced "shammy") is the padded insert in cycling shorts. It cushions the contact points between you and the saddle,

reduces friction, and helps prevent saddle sores. After your helmet, this is possibly the most important piece of comfort gear.

You have two options:

- **Lycra cycling shorts** — The tight, form-fitting kind. Maximum comfort and performance. Minimum style points, unless you're very confident.
- **Baggy MTB shorts with liner** — Baggy outer shorts over a snug chamois liner. Same functionality, more modest appearance, and pockets for your energy bars and phone. This is what most Brasília riders wear.

Budget: R\$100-300 for decent baggy shorts with liner.

Critical rule: Never wear underwear under chamois shorts. The chamois IS the underwear. Wearing boxers or briefs underneath defeats the purpose and creates friction. This seems obvious to experienced riders, but every beginner makes this mistake once. Only once.

Jersey/Shirt

You can ride in a cotton t-shirt. People do. But a proper cycling jersey or moisture-wicking athletic shirt makes a noticeable difference in comfort, especially on longer rides.

In Brasília's heat, you want something lightweight, breathable, and quick-drying. Synthetic fabrics (polyester, nylon) or merino wool blends are ideal. Avoid cotton — it absorbs sweat, gets heavy, and takes forever to dry.

Budget: R\$50-200.

Shoes

Your shoes depend on your pedal system:

Flat pedals + flat shoes: The simplest setup. Flat pedals have a wide platform with pins that grip your shoe. You wear shoes with a flat, sticky rubber sole (like Five Ten or similar MTB flat shoes). Easy to put your foot down, easy to walk, and the most beginner-friendly setup.

Clipless pedals + clipless shoes: "Clipless" is a confusing name — it actually means you clip in to the pedals using a cleat on the bottom of your shoe. This creates a secure connection that lets you pull up on the pedals as well as push down, improving efficiency. Shimano SPD is the most common MTB clipless system.

For beginners, I recommend starting with flat pedals. Learn to ride first, then consider upgrading to clipless once you're confident on the trails. For the cerrado's terrain, where you often need to put a foot down quickly on rocky sections or creek crossings, flats are forgiving.

André's Tip: If you ride flats, invest in proper MTB flat shoes rather than random sneakers. The difference in grip is enormous — good flat shoes stick to the pedals like glue. Five Ten makes the gold standard, but brands like Shimano and Ride Concepts offer good options too. In Brasília, you can find them at most bike shops in Asa Norte.

Hydration & Nutrition

This section could save your ride — or your health.

Water

Brasília's climate demands serious hydration. During the dry season, with humidity below 20% and temperatures above 25°C, you can lose over a liter of sweat per hour of riding. You won't always feel thirsty —

the dry air evaporates sweat so fast that you don't feel wet. But you are losing water, and if you wait until you feel thirsty, you're already behind.

My minimums:

- Rides under 1 hour: 1 liter
- Rides 1-2 hours: 2 liters
- Rides 2-4 hours: 3 liters
- Rides 4+ hours: 3+ liters plus electrolyte supplementation

Carrying options:

- **Water bottles** in frame cages — Simple, cheap, accessible. Two bottles = ~1.4 liters. Works for shorter rides.
- **Hydration pack** (backpack with water bladder) — The preferred option for longer rides. A 2-3 liter bladder plus the ability to carry snacks, tools, and extra gear. Brands like CamelBak, Osprey, and Deuter are widely available in Brasília.

Electrolytes: On rides over 90 minutes, plain water isn't enough. You need to replace sodium, potassium, and magnesium lost through sweat. Electrolyte tabs (like Endurolytes or simple salt tabs) are cheap, light, and can prevent cramping and bonking.

Food

For rides under 90 minutes, you probably don't need food. Over that, your body needs fuel.

What works:

- Energy gels (available at bike shops and pharmacies in Brasília)
- Rapadura (sugarcane candy) — the Brazilian trailside classic, cheap and effective
- Bananas — nature's energy bar, and available at every feira (street market) for centavos

- Pão de queijo — cheese bread. Not the most scientific choice, but a trailhead pão de queijo and coffee is basically a spiritual experience
- Dates, nuts, and castanha do Pará (Brazil nuts) — calorie-dense and pack well

André's Tip: Rapadura is my secret weapon. It's basically concentrated sugarcane — pure carbohydrate energy in a compact, indestructible block that costs R\$2 at any supermarket. Break it into chunks, wrap them in foil, and stash them in your pack. When your legs are dying on a climb, a chunk of rapadura brings you back to life. Every Brazilian rider knows this trick.

The Repair Kit: Be Self-Sufficient

Trails in Brasília can be remote. Cell service is unreliable once you're outside the urban core. If something breaks twenty kilometers from the trailhead, you need to fix it yourself. Here's what to carry:

The Essentials:

- **Spare inner tube** (correct size for your tire) — or two, if you're going far
- **Tire levers** (2-3)
- **Mini pump** or **CO2 inflator** with cartridges
- **Multi-tool** with hex wrenches (4mm, 5mm, 6mm), Torx T25, Phillips and flat screwdrivers, chain breaker
- **Quick links** (for your chain — carry two that match your drivetrain speed)
- **Tire boot** (a piece of tough material — a section of old tire, a dollar bill, or a commercial tire boot — for patching sidewall cuts)

- **Zip ties** — the duct tape of the trail. Can temporarily fix almost anything

Nice to have:

- Tubeless repair kit (if you run tubeless tires — bacon strips and a plug tool)
- Spare derailleur hanger (they're bike-specific and snap easily)
- Small roll of electrical tape

Know how to use it: Carrying a repair kit you can't use is like carrying a parachute you can't open. Before your first big ride, practice changing a tube at home. Watch a YouTube video on using a chain breaker. Learn where the bolts are on your bike and what size hex wrench each one needs. Twenty minutes of practice at home saves two hours of frustration on the trail.

André's Tip: I keep a fully stocked repair kit in my hydration pack at all times — it never comes out, it's always ready. The morning I forget to check it will be the morning I get a flat 15 kilometers from the car. Murphy's Law is fluent in Portuguese.

Sun Protection

The sun in Brasília is fierce. At 1,100+ meters of elevation and only 15° south of the equator, UV radiation is intense. Combine this with the dry season's clear skies and hours of exposure on the bike, and sunburn is a serious concern.

- **Sunscreen:** SPF 50+, sweat-proof. Apply before the ride and reapply at rest stops. Don't forget your ears, neck, and the backs of your hands.
- **Lip balm with SPF:** Your lips will crack in the dry season without it.

- **Arm sleeves:** UV-protective sleeves are lighter and cooler than sunscreen, and many riders prefer them. They also protect from branches and scrapes.
- **Buff/neck gaiter:** Protects the neck and can be pulled up over the face in dusty conditions.

Electronics & Navigation

Phone

Your phone is your camera, your GPS, your emergency communication device, and your connection to trail maps and group chats. Protect it.

- **Waterproof case or dry bag** — Essential, especially in the rainy season
- **Phone mount** — If you use your phone for navigation, a bar-mounted holder keeps it visible. Quad Lock and SP Connect make secure options that can handle rough trails.
- **Portable charger** — A small power bank (10,000 mAh) can keep your phone alive on all-day rides. GPS tracking drains batteries fast.

GPS & Trail Maps

- **Wikiloc** — The most-used trail app in Brasília. Thousands of local GPS tracks uploaded by riders. Download offline maps before you ride.
- **Strava** — For tracking your rides and competing on segments. Brasília has an active Strava community.
- **Komoot** — Good for route planning with turn-by-turn navigation.
- **Bike computers** — Garmin Edge and Wahoo Elemnt are popular. Not necessary for beginners, but useful for tracking and navigation on longer rides.

First Aid Kit

Keep it small, keep it relevant:

- Adhesive bandages (various sizes)
- Gauze pads and medical tape
- Antiseptic wipes
- Tweezers (for thorns and carrapato tick removal)
- Antihistamine (for insect stings)
- Pain relief (ibuprofen)
- Emergency contact card with your blood type and any allergies

The Gear Checklist

Here's what I grab before every ride, organized by how quickly I'd notice if I forgot it:

Would notice immediately:

- ☐ Helmet
- ☐ Shoes
- ☐ Hydration pack (filled)
- ☐ Phone

Would notice at the trailhead:

- ☐ Gloves
- ☐ Sunglasses
- ☐ Sunscreen
- ☐ Repair kit

Would notice mid-ride:

- ☐ Food/snacks
- ☐ Electrolytes
- ☐ Cash (for waterfall entry fees, emergencies)

Would notice only if I needed it:

- ☐ First aid kit
- ☐ Rain jacket (rainy season)
- ☐ Lights (if any chance of riding past sunset)
- ☐ Spare tube

Print this. Tape it inside your gear closet. Check it before you leave. I promise it'll save you a U-turn someday.

Chapter 5: Preparing for Your Ride — Safety, Fitness & the Pre- Ride Checklist



POV from the handlebars — the singletrack perspective that
awaits every prepared rider

The ride doesn't start at the trailhead. It starts the night before, when you check the weather forecast. It starts in the morning, when you pump your tires and fill your water bladder. It starts with the boring, unsexy work of preparation that nobody posts on Instagram but that separates a great ride from a miserable one.

I learned this the hard way.

My third month in Brasília, I rode out to Córrego do Ouro without checking the weather, without enough water, and without telling anyone where I was going. The sky opened up, I got caught in a thunderstorm on an exposed ridge, ran out of water on the climb back, and my phone died. I spent two hours pushing my bike through mud in the dark before finding a road.

I was fine. But I didn't need to be. Bad preparation almost made that day terrible instead of just inconvenient.

This chapter is about making sure that doesn't happen to you.

Physical Preparation

Fitness for Mountain Biking

Let me be clear: **you do not need to be an athlete to start mountain biking.** The trails in Chapter 6 are designed for normal humans. If you can ride a bicycle for 30 minutes without feeling like you're going to die, you're ready for a beginner trail in Brasília.

That said, mountain biking is a workout. Brasília's trails involve climbing — sometimes a lot of climbing. The more fit you are, the more you'll enjoy the riding and the more trails you'll be able to access.

Cardiovascular fitness is the biggest limiter. If your heart and lungs can't keep up with the demands of a climb, it doesn't matter how strong

your legs are. The good news: riding a bike builds cardiovascular fitness. Start easy, ride consistently, and your fitness will improve fast.

Leg strength matters for climbing and bike handling. Squats, lunges, and step-ups are all useful exercises. But honestly, the best training for mountain biking is mountain biking. Ride more, and your legs will adapt.

Core strength is underrated. A strong core helps you control the bike on technical terrain, absorb impacts, and maintain good posture over long rides. Simple exercises — planks, dead bugs, bird dogs — done a few times a week make a real difference.

Grip strength matters because you're holding handlebars for hours, often over rough terrain that tries to shake the bike out of your hands. If your forearms cramp before your legs do, work on grip strength.

Building Your Base

If you're starting from zero or coming back after a long break, here's a simple progression:

Weeks 1-4: Ride 2-3 times per week, 30-60 minutes each, on easy terrain. Focus on getting comfortable on the bike, building basic fitness, and establishing a habit. No pressure, no Strava, no ego.

Weeks 5-8: Increase duration to 60-90 minutes. Add one ride per week with some hills. Start exploring beginner trails (Chapter 6).

Weeks 9-12: Push to 90-120 minutes on longer rides. Tackle intermediate trails (Chapter 7). Join a group ride for motivation and company.

Month 4+: You're a mountain biker. Keep riding, keep pushing, keep exploring.

André's Tip: Don't train by the clock — train by perceived effort. In Brasília's heat, especially in the dry season, a 60-minute ride at

moderate effort can feel like 90 minutes anywhere else. Listen to your body. If you're struggling, slow down. The trails will still be there tomorrow. Devagar se vai ao longe — slowly you go far, as we say in Portuguese.

Altitude Adjustment

Brasília sits at approximately 1,100 meters above sea level. If you're coming from sea level, you might feel the altitude during your first few rides — slightly more breathlessness, slightly faster fatigue. It's not extreme (this isn't La Paz), but it's noticeable.

Give yourself 2-3 days to adjust before attempting anything ambitious. Stay hydrated (altitude + dry air = rapid dehydration), and don't push too hard on your first rides. By day 4-5, most people have fully adjusted.

Safety on the Trail

The Golden Rules

1. **Never ride alone on unfamiliar trails without telling someone where you're going and when you expect to return.** This is the most important safety rule in mountain biking. A broken collarbone twenty kilometers from the trailhead is survivable; a broken collarbone that nobody knows about for two days is dangerous.
2. **Carry more water than you think you need.** See Chapter 4. Then add a little more.
3. **Wear your helmet.** See Chapter 4. I won't say it again. (Yes I will.)
4. **Respect your limits.** There is no shame in walking a section that scares you. There is no shame in turning back when you're tired. There

is massive shame in getting airlifted because your ego wrote checks your skills couldn't cash.

5. **Check the weather.** Brasília's afternoon thunderstorms are violent and sudden. Lightning on an exposed trail is no joke.

Trail-Specific Hazards in Brasília

Loose laterite (red gravel): The red clay soil of the cerrado, when dry, creates a fine, loose gravel on the trail surface that can behave like marbles under your tires. Especially dangerous on descents and corners. Lower your speed, keep your weight back, and avoid sudden braking.

Exposed roots: Gallery forest sections are beautiful but treacherous. Tree roots cross the trail constantly, and when wet, they are as slick as ice. Cross roots at an angle when possible, stay loose on the bike, and avoid braking on the root itself.

Creek crossings: Most Brasília trails cross streams at some point. In the dry season, these are often just damp rock beds. In the rainy season, they can be knee-deep with a current. Always scout a crossing before riding through if you can't see the bottom. Check depth with your foot. The rocks are often slimy.

Sand patches: Some trails, particularly those near limestone areas, have sections of deep sand that can grab your front wheel and stop you dead. When you hit sand, shift your weight back, keep pedaling, and don't fight the handlebars — let the bike wander slightly.

Wildlife encounters: Capybaras won't bother you. Snakes might if you bother them. The real threats are the small things: carrapatos (ticks) in tall grass, marimbondos (wasps) whose nests hang from branches at handlebar height, and fire ants that colonize trailside rest spots. Carry tweezers for ticks, check yourself post-ride, and look before you sit down.

Other trail users: You'll encounter hikers, runners, horseback riders, and other cyclists on many trails. The universal rule: bikes yield to horses and pedestrians. Slow down, announce yourself ("Passando!" — "Coming through!"), and be friendly. We're all sharing the cerrado.

André's Tip: I got nailed by a marimbondo (wasp) nest on a trail near Fercal at full speed. The welts lasted a week. Now I scan the trail 10-15 meters ahead as I ride, especially on narrow singletrack. If you see something hanging from a branch at chest or head height, slow down and steer wide. Better paranoid than stung.

First Aid Basics for the Trail

Crashes happen. Know the basics:

Cuts and scrapes (the most common injury): Clean with water, apply antiseptic, bandage. Keep riding if it's minor. Most trail wounds look worse than they are because they're covered in red dirt.

Suspected fracture: Immobilize the area, don't try to set it, and get to medical help. In Brasília, the nearest hospital (pronto-socorro) depends on your location — know the closest one before you ride. Dial **192** (SAMU ambulance) or **193** (fire department/rescue) for emergencies.

Heat exhaustion: Brasília's dry heat is sneaky. Symptoms include dizziness, nausea, excessive sweating (or sudden cessation of sweating), confusion. Get into shade, drink water with electrolytes, pour water on your head and neck, and rest. If symptoms don't improve in 15-20 minutes, get to medical help.

Dehydration: By the time you feel dehydrated, you've been dehydrated for a while. Prevention is the only cure. Drink before you're thirsty.

Emergency Information

Keep this in your phone and on a card in your pack:

- **SAMU (Emergency Medical):** 192
- **Bombeiros (Fire/Rescue):** 193
- **Polícia Militar:** 190
- **Your blood type**
- **Your allergies**
- **Emergency contact name and phone**

The Pre-Ride Checklist

I do this before every single ride. It takes five minutes. It's prevented dozens of problems.

The Night Before

- ☐ Check weather forecast (especially afternoon rain probability)
- ☐ Charge phone and bike lights
- ☐ Plan route — download GPS track to phone for offline use
- ☐ Tell someone where you're going and when you expect to return
- ☐ Set alarm (early rides are the best rides)

Morning Of

- ☐ **Tires:** Check pressure. Run 25-30 PSI for most trail tires (lower for more grip in wet conditions, higher for faster rolling in dry). If tubeless, check sealant level monthly.
- ☐ **Brakes:** Squeeze both levers. Each should engage firmly before hitting the bar. If spongy, they need bleeding. Don't ride with bad brakes.

- ☐ **Chain:** Run it through a rag. It should be clean-ish and lubed. A dry chain destroys drivetrains.
- ☐ **Bolts:** Quick check of stem bolts, handlebar bolts, seat clamp, and axle thru-bolts. Anything loose? Fix it now.
- ☐ **Suspension:** Bounce the fork and shock. Should compress and rebound smoothly. Air spring at correct pressure for your weight.
- ☐ **Water:** Fill bladder/bottles. Add electrolytes if riding over 90 minutes.
- ☐ **Food:** Pack enough for the duration plus emergency extra.
- ☐ **Repair kit:** Confirm tube, pump, levers, multi-tool are present.
- ☐ **Sunscreen:** Apply before you leave. It's harder to apply well once you're sweaty.

At the Trailhead

- ☐ Final tire pressure check (tires can lose pressure overnight)
- ☐ GPS track loaded and recording
- ☐ Helmet on and adjusted
- ☐ Gloves and sunglasses on
- ☐ Take a deep breath and smile

You're ready.

André's Tip: Make the pre-ride check a ritual, not a chore. I have a hook in my garage where my hydration pack lives, always stocked with repair kit and first aid. My pump lives next to the door. My sunscreen lives in the car. Everything has a place, so the morning check takes four minutes. Build the system once, trust it forever.

Riding Etiquette: The Unwritten Rules

Brazilian trail culture is warm and generous, but there are expectations:

Greet everyone. A "Bom dia!" (Good morning!) or "Boa tarde!" (Good afternoon!) to every person you pass — riders, hikers, runners, garis (workers). This is Brazil. We greet people. It costs nothing and builds goodwill.

Leave no trace. Pack out everything you pack in. Energy gel wrappers, banana peels, empty bottles — it all comes back with you. The cerrado is pristine because riders keep it that way.

Don't cut trails. Ride the marked trail. Don't create shortcuts, don't widen corners, don't ride around muddy sections (that creates wider mud). Stay on the trail and let the terrain challenge you.

Yield uphill. If you're descending and a rider is coming up, yield. Climbing requires momentum — once you lose it, you have to start over. Descending, you can easily stop and restart. Give the climber the right of way.

Help stopped riders. If you see someone stopped on the trail looking at their bike with a confused expression, stop and ask "Tá tudo bem?" (Everything okay?). This is non-negotiable. The cerrado is remote, and community means looking out for each other.

Close gates. Many trails cross fazenda (farm) property with gates. If you open it, close it. If it's closed, leave it closed. Farmers tolerate cyclists because we're respectful. One open gate that lets cattle out ruins it for everyone.

Mental Preparation

One more thing before we hit the trails.

Mountain biking, especially on new terrain, involves discomfort. Your legs will burn on climbs. You'll be hot. You'll face sections that scare you. You'll be far from your car and wondering why you thought this was a good idea.

This is normal. This is the sport. And here's the secret: the suffering is what makes the reward so sweet.

When you crest that climb and the entire Planalto Central opens up before you, drenched in golden light, with nothing but birdsong and your own breathing — the burn in your legs becomes a badge of honor. When you splash through a creek crossing and somehow stay upright, you'll let out a whoop that echoes off the gallery forest walls. When you roll back to the trailhead, coated in red dirt and sweat, and someone hands you a cold guaraná — you'll understand.

The preparation gets you to the trail. The fitness gets you through the trail. But the joy — that's built into the riding itself.

Let's go find some trails.

Part III: The Trails

Chapter 6: Trail Guide — Beginner Trails



The classic red dirt trail of the cerrado — where every Brasília
rider's journey begins

This is where it begins.

Forget what you've seen on YouTube — the cliff drops, the rock gardens, the riders launching off jumps with photographers capturing mid-air perfection. That's not where mountain biking starts. Mountain biking starts on a dirt road with a gentle slope, a little bit of gravel, and the feeling that you're leaving the pavement — and the ordinary — behind.

Brasília has some of the best beginner-friendly trails I've ridden anywhere. Wide enough to feel safe, scenic enough to feel rewarded, and just challenging enough to feel like you accomplished something. These are the trails where I fell in love with this sport. They might be where you do too.

How to Read the Trail Descriptions

Each trail in this book follows a standard format:

- **Distance:** Total ride distance in kilometers
- **Elevation Gain:** Total climbing in meters
- **Difficulty:** Beginner / Intermediate / Advanced
- **Time:** Estimated riding time (not including stops)
- **Surface:** What you'll be riding on
- **Water:** Is there water available on-trail?
- **Trailhead GPS:** Starting coordinates
- **Best Season:** When the trail is at its best
- **Highlights:** The best parts of the ride

I also include my personal rating — a totally subjective, biased assessment based on how much I enjoyed the ride and how likely I am to drag friends there.

Trail 1: FLONA Rota 1 — Circuito Iniciante



FLONA trail signpost — the gateway to Brasília's crown jewel trail system

Distance: 5 km

Elevation Gain: ~80m

Difficulty: Beginner

Time: 30-45 minutes

Surface: Packed dirt road, some gravel

Water: No on-trail water; bring your own

Trailhead GPS: -15.748, -47.955 (FLONA main entrance, Lago Oeste side)

Best Season: Year-round (slightly muddy in peak rainy season)

Highlights: Cerrado immersion, professional signage, wildlife

André's Rating: [] [] [] [] — The perfect first ride in Brasília

The Ride

FLONA — the Floresta Nacional de Brasília (Brasília National Forest) — is the crown jewel of Brasília's trail system, and Rota 1 is the entry point.

This 5-kilometer loop is specifically designed for beginners and families. The trail follows wide, packed-dirt fire roads through classic cerrado vegetation, with gentle grades that never get steep enough to be scary. Every intersection is signposted with route numbers, difficulty ratings, and distances. QR codes on the posts link to GPS tracks you can follow on your phone.

The beauty of Rota 1 isn't the technical challenge — there isn't one. The beauty is the cerrado itself. Within minutes of leaving the trailhead, you're surrounded by twisted pau-terra trees, golden grasses, and the distinctive red earth that gives the region its character. Keep your eyes up: toucans frequent the gallery forest edges, and I've seen capybaras on the creek crossings even on this short loop.

This is where I take every visitor for their first ride. Without exception.

André's Tip: Arrive early — by 7:00 AM on weekends. FLONA gets popular, and the morning light in the cerrado is impossibly beautiful. The air is cool, the birds are active, and you'll have the trail mostly to yourself. Plus, you'll be done before the heat peaks.

Trail 2: Parque da Cidade Sarah Kubitschek — Urban Ride

Distance: 5-15 km (multiple loops)

Elevation Gain: Minimal (50-100m)

Difficulty: Beginner

Time: 30-90 minutes depending on route

Surface: Mixed — paved paths and packed dirt

Water: Water fountains and vendors in park

Trailhead GPS: -15.802, -47.913 (main park entrance, Asa Sul)

Best Season: Year-round

Highlights: Central location, family-friendly, views of TV Tower

André's Rating:  — Not really mountain biking, but a great introduction to cycling in Brasília

The Ride

At 420 hectares, the Parque da Cidade (City Park) is one of Latin America's largest urban parks, and it's threaded with paths that make a perfect gentle introduction to off-road cycling.

The park has a mix of paved paths and dirt trails, with gentle rolling terrain that's suitable for absolute beginners and families with children. The iconic TV Tower (Torre de TV) provides a constant landmark so you can't get lost. Water fountains are plentiful, there are lanchonetes (snack bars) scattered throughout, and the atmosphere on weekend mornings is pure Brazilian joy — runners, cyclists, families with kids, dogs, forró music playing from someone's speaker.

This isn't wilderness mountain biking. But if you've never ridden a bike off-road before, this is the place to get comfortable before heading to the cerrado.

Trail 3: Lago Paranoá Circuit — The Lakeside Loop

Distance: 14-25 km (depending on route variation)

Elevation Gain: ~150-250m

Difficulty: Beginner to Beginner+

Time: 1-2 hours

Surface: Dirt road, some pavement, packed trail

Water: Restaurants and gas stations near the lake

Trailhead GPS: -15.823, -47.847 (multiple access points around the lake)

Best Season: Year-round

Highlights: Lake views, Ponte JK, Palácio da Alvorada, flat-ish terrain

André's Rating: ☐☐☐☐ — The most scenic easy ride in the city

The Ride

Lago Paranoá is the artificial lake that fills the center of Brasília's Plano Piloto (Pilot Plan), and riding around parts of it is one of the city's great cycling experiences.

The full circumference of the lake is approximately 80 kilometers, but several shorter routes let you enjoy the lakeside without committing to a full day. The most popular beginner-friendly section runs along the eastern shore, where a mix of dirt roads and paths offer views of the water, the Ponte JK bridge, and — if you ride the right section — the Palácio da Alvorada, the president's official residence.

The terrain is gentle, with only mild elevation changes. The surface is mostly packed dirt and gravel, with some paved sections. There's shade from trees along parts of the route, and you're never far from civilization — restaurants, gas stations, and quiosques (kiosks) dot the lakeside.

This is a ride for the views, not the challenge. Do it at sunset for the full experience.

André's Tip: The section near the Ermida Dom Bosco — a small chapel on the lake's southern shore — has one of the best sunset views in Brasília. Time your ride to arrive there for golden hour. The combination of the lake, the sky, and Niemeyer's buildings in the distance is worth a thousand photos.

Trail 4: FLONA Rota 2 — Stepping Up

Distance: 12 km

Elevation Gain: ~180m

Difficulty: Beginner+

Time: 1-1.5 hours

Surface: Dirt road and packed singletrack

Water: No on-trail water

Trailhead GPS: -15.748, -47.955 (FLONA main entrance)

Best Season: May-November (can be muddy in heavy rains)

Highlights: Longer cerrado immersion, wildlife, first taste of singletrack

André's Rating: [★★★★] — The ride that hooks you

The Ride

If Rota 1 is your first date with Brasília's cerrado, Rota 2 is when you fall in love.

This 12-kilometer route builds on the same trail network but ventures deeper into FLONA's conservation area. You'll still ride mostly on dirt roads, but sections of narrower trail introduce you to the feeling of singletrack — a trail just wide enough for one bike, winding through vegetation that brushes your handlebars.

The elevation gain is still modest at around 180 meters, but you'll feel the climbs more than on Rota 1. The descents are fun without being scary — gentle slopes on packed dirt where you can practice carrying speed and reading the trail.

This is where the cerrado really opens up. The route passes through several vegetation zones: open campo limpo on the ridges with sweeping views, dense cerradão forest in the valleys, and beautiful mata de galeria near the creek crossings. Wildlife sightings are more common here — I've seen deer, toucans, and once a pair of hyacinth macaws that made me stop dead in my tracks.

Trail 5: Catingueiro (Beginner Variation)

Distance: 15 km (shortened version)

Elevation Gain: ~250m

Difficulty: Beginner+ (shortened version avoids the harder sections)

Time: 1-1.5 hours

Surface: Dirt road, packed gravel

Water: No on-trail water

Trailhead GPS: -15.585, -47.845 (concentração Vila Boa Vista)

Best Season: May-October

Highlights: Rolling cerrado, rural scenery, great for building endurance

André's Rating: ☐☐☐ — Honest work on honest dirt

The Ride

Catingueiro is technically an intermediate trail (the full 27-kilometer version is covered in Chapter 7), but the first 15 kilometers can be ridden as a standalone beginner-plus route that stays on the wider, less technical dirt roads.

Starting from Vila Boa Vista, the route follows estradas de terra (dirt roads) through rolling cerrado and rural farmland. There's nothing technically challenging — no rock gardens, no significant singletrack, no steep descents. What there is: honest climbing, beautiful scenery, and the kind of ride that builds the endurance foundation you'll need for bigger adventures.

This is a training ride, not a destination ride. It's where you go to put in the kilometers and build your legs for the trails ahead.

Trail 6: Parque Vivencial do Lago Norte

Distance: 8 km (loop options)

Elevation Gain: ~100m

Difficulty: Beginner

Time: 45-60 minutes

Surface: Packed dirt, some sand

Water: No on-trail water

Trailhead GPS: -15.724, -47.843 (park entrance, Lago Norte)

Best Season: May-September (sandy/muddy in rains)

Highlights: Wetland scenery, birdwatching, close to Lago Norte residential area

André's Rating: ☐☐☐☐ — A pleasant escape without leaving the city

The Ride

Tucked into the Lago Norte residential area, this small park offers a network of trails that wind through wetland-adjacent cerrado. The trails are mostly flat, well-shaded, and peaceful — a world away from the city despite being minutes from supermarkets and restaurants.

It's not a trail you travel across Brasília for, but if you live nearby or want a quick, easy ride without the drive to FLONA, it's perfect. The birdwatching is surprisingly good, with herons, kingfishers, and the occasional socó (tiger-heron) in the marshy areas.

Watch for sandy patches, especially in the dry season — they can grab your front wheel if you're not expecting them.

General Tips for Beginner Riders

Start Early

In Brasília, the best riding hours are **6:00-10:00 AM**. Temperatures are cooler, the light is beautiful, and the trails are less crowded. By noon, the sun is fierce. By 2:00 PM in the dry season, you'll feel like you're riding inside an oven.

Ride With Someone

Your first few trail rides should be with an experienced rider or a group. They'll show you the route, warn you about hazards, and help if anything goes wrong. Join a beginner group ride through Rebas do Cerrado or ask at your local bike shop — someone will gladly take you out.

Walk When You Need To

There is zero shame in dismounting and walking a section that feels beyond your skill level. Every advanced rider in Brasília walked sections when they were starting. The trail doesn't judge you. Push your bike up that hill, remount at the top, and enjoy the descent.

Celebrate Small Wins

The first time you ride a full 10 kilometers without stopping. The first time you clear a creek crossing without putting a foot down. The first time you look at a 20-kilometer route and think "I can do that." These are milestones. Celebrate them. You're a mountain biker now.

André's Tip: After your first few rides, you're going to be sore in places you didn't know existed. Your bunda (butt), your forearms,

your lower back. This is normal. It gets better fast — by ride five or six, the soreness fades and you start to feel the bike as an extension of your body. Push through the first week. I promise it's worth it.

Chapter 7: Trail Guide — Intermediate Trails



Golden singletrack stretching through the cerrado — where
intermediate riders find their rhythm

So you've done the beginner trails. Your legs don't burn after 15 kilometers anymore. You've stopped white-knuckling every descent. You caught yourself grinning on a singletrack section and thought: I want more.

Welcome to intermediate.

This is where Brasília's trail system really starts to shine. The routes get longer, the terrain gets more varied, the climbs get honest, and the descents reward good technique. You'll need fitness, focus, and a willingness to push your comfort zone. In return, you'll get some of the best riding in South America.

These trails are my daily bread. Most of my regular rides fall into this category — long enough to be a workout, technical enough to be interesting, and scenic enough to make me forget I'm exercising.

Trail 7: FLONA Rotas 3-5 — The Heart of the Forest

Distance: 15-25 km (depending on route combination)

Elevation Gain: 250-450m

Difficulty: Intermediate

Time: 1.5-3 hours

Surface: Singletrack, dirt road, packed clay, some rocky sections

Water: Creek crossings (not potable); bring your own

Trailhead GPS: -15.748, -47.955 (FLONA main entrance)

Best Season: May-October (rideable year-round but muddy Dec-Mar)

Highlights: Deep cerrado immersion, varied terrain, excellent signage

André's Rating: ☐☐☐☐☐ — The quintessential Brasília mountain bike ride

The Ride

FLONA's intermediate routes — Rotas 3 through 5 — are where you discover what this forest is truly about.

These routes link together to create options ranging from 15 to 25 kilometers, mixing wide fire roads with genuine singletrack that winds through the heart of the conservation area. The signage is impeccable — color-coded posts at every junction, distance markers, difficulty warnings before technical sections. You'd have to actively try to get lost.

The terrain shifts constantly. You'll pedal through open campo limpo with views that stretch to the horizon, then plunge into cerradão forest so dense the temperature drops five degrees. Creek crossings appear with increasing frequency, some rideable, some requiring a dismount.

Rocky sections test your line choice. Short, punchy climbs test your power. Flowing descents through red dirt reward your skills.

Rota 4, in particular, is my favorite FLONA route. It follows a ridge through classic cerrado, then drops into a valley with one of the prettiest gallery forest sections in the entire DF. The creek at the bottom is crystal-clear, and in the dry season, it's a perfect rest stop — dip your bottles, splash your face, sit on a rock for five minutes and listen to the bem-te-vi birds calling from the canopy.

André's Tip: FLONA's routes can be combined and customized. I often ride a "greatest hits" loop: start on Rota 3, connect to Rota 4 for the ridge and valley section, then return on Rota 5 for a different perspective. Total: about 22 km with 380m of climbing. It's my go-to Wednesday ride.

Trail 8: Catingueiro — Full Loop

Distance: 27 km

Elevation Gain: ~550m

Difficulty: Intermediate

Time: 2-3 hours

Surface: Dirt road, packed clay, some singletrack sections

Water: No reliable on-trail water

Trailhead GPS: -15.585, -47.845 (concentração Vila Boa Vista)

Best Season: May-October

Highlights: Endurance builder, rolling terrain, rural cerrado beauty

André's Rating: ☐☐☐☐ — The ride that builds legs

The Ride

Catingueiro is what I call a "rhythm ride." There aren't any single features that stand out — no dramatic waterfalls, no terrifying descents, no Instagram-bait viewpoints. What there is: 27 kilometers of honest, rolling cerrado terrain that rewards smooth pedaling and punishes anyone who goes out too hard too early.

Starting from Vila Boa Vista, the route follows a mix of dirt roads and packed clay trails through rural cerrado. The climbing is relentless but never severe — short grades of 5-8% that stack up over the distance. The total elevation gain of 550 meters sneaks up on you. By kilometer 20, your legs will know they've been working.

The scenery is quintessential Planalto Central: wide horizons, scattered farms, cerrado vegetation in various stages of regeneration. It's not

dramatic the way FLONA is dramatic, but there's a quiet beauty to it that grows on you.

This is a resistance-training ride. I use it to build my base fitness, and I send intermediate riders here to find out what they're made of. If you can do Catingueiro comfortably, you're ready for the advanced trails in Chapter 8.

Trail 9: Trilha 3 Riachos — Three Creeks



Splashing through a cerrado creek crossing — water, speed, and pure joy

Distance: 22 km

Elevation Gain: ~400m

Difficulty: Intermediate+

Time: 2-3 hours

Surface: Singletrack, creek crossings, packed dirt, some rocky sections

Water: Three creek crossings (not potable)

Trailhead GPS: Concentração at UPA Sobradinho II

Best Season: May-September (creek crossings may be impassable in heavy rains)

Highlights: Water features, gallery forest, technical creek crossings

André's Rating: [] [] [] [] [] — The most fun intermediate trail in the region

The Ride

Three Creeks. The name says it all.

This trail, starting from the UPA (urgent care clinic) in Sobradinho II, threads through cerrado and gallery forest, crossing three distinct creeks that define the ride. In the dry season, the crossings are manageable — shin to knee-deep, with rocky bottoms that test your balance and line choice. In the rainy season, they can become serious obstacles.

Between the crossings, the trail delivers excellent singletrack through varied cerrado terrain. There are sections of flowing, fast dirt through campo sujo; technical, rooty sections through gallery forest; and short, punchy climbs that reward explosive power. The descents before each creek crossing are particularly fun — just enough grade and length to build speed and practice braking control.

The mata de galeria (gallery forest) sections around the three creeks are stunning. These green corridors — cool, shaded, and alive with birds and butterflies — feel like secret passages through the cerrado. The contrast between the open, dry terrain and these lush green tunnels is one of the defining experiences of riding in Brasília.

André's Tip: If you ride Trilha 3 Riachos in the first weeks after the rainy season ends (May-June), the creeks are still running strong and the gallery forests are at their greenest. It's the sweet spot — dry enough to ride, wet enough to be spectacular. Bring shoes you don't mind getting soaked.

Trail 10: Trilha Olaria — The Waterfall Ride

Distance: 41 km

Elevation Gain: ~600m

Difficulty: Intermediate+

Time: 3-4 hours (plus waterfall time!)

Surface: Dirt road, singletrack, farm roads

Water: Waterfalls and creeks on-trail

Trailhead GPS: Varies — check Wikiloc for current starting points

Best Season: May-September (best waterfall flow in May-July)

Highlights: Cachoeira Três Quedas, rural scenery, Fazenda Xanguí

André's Rating: ☐☐☐☐☐ — My favorite ride in all of Brasília. Period.

The Ride

This is the one.

If you ride one intermediate trail in Brasília, make it Trilha Olaria. Not because it's the most technical or the most challenging — it's neither. Because it's the perfect marriage of riding and reward.

The 41-kilometer route follows dirt roads and farm tracks through rolling cerrado to Fazenda Xanguí, a private property that hosts one of the most beautiful waterfall complexes in the DF: Cachoeira Três Quedas (Three Falls Waterfall). There's an entry fee of R\$10 per bike — the best ten reais you'll spend in Brasília.

The riding itself is solid intermediate fare: long dirt road sections that test your endurance, some singletrack diversions that test your skills, and enough climbing to make you earn your reward. The scenery shifts

from suburban fringe to rural farmland to deep cerrado as you get further from the city.

And then you arrive at the falls.

Three distinct cascades tumble into clear pools surrounded by rocks and vegetation. The swimming is incredible — cool cerrado water on hot skin after three hours of riding. Bring a towel, bring a dry bag for your phone, and plan to spend at least an hour here. Some riders bring lunch and make a day of it.

The return ride is the same route in reverse, which normally I'd consider a negative. But after swimming in Três Quedas, you're so refreshed that the return feels like a different ride.

André's Tip: Bring R\$10 cash for the Fazenda Xanguí entry fee and R\$20-30 extra for the lanchonete (snack bar) at the farm. They sell cold drinks, pastéis (fried pastries), and sometimes caldo de cana (fresh sugarcane juice). Trust me — a cold caldo de cana after 20 km of riding is a religious experience.

Trail 11: Chapada Imperial — Cerrado Crown

Distance: 20-30 km (multiple route options)

Elevation Gain: 400-700m

Difficulty: Intermediate to Intermediate+

Time: 2-4 hours

Surface: Rocky singletrack, dirt road, technical sections

Water: Streams on some routes; bring your own

Trailhead GPS: -15.48, -47.95 (approximate — varies by route)

Best Season: May-September

Highlights: High cerrado, rock formations, valley views, wildlife

André's Rating: ☐☐☐☐ — Wild, remote-feeling riding surprisingly close to the city

The Ride

Chapada Imperial is a private ecological reserve that offers some of the most dramatic terrain accessible from Brasília. The landscape here feels different from the gentler cerrado of FLONA — more elevation, more rock, more of the rugged chapada (plateau/tableland) character that defines the Planalto Central's geography.

Several routes wind through the reserve, ranging from moderate dirt-road loops to more technical singletrack with rocky sections that demand good line choice. The signature feature is the elevation: routes here climb higher than most Brasília trails, reaching viewpoints where the cerrado drops away in valleys that seem to go on forever.

The more technical routes include the Trilha da Capivara — a 12-kilometer loop with rocky terrain, challenging climbs, and sections of genuine singletrack through dense cerrado. It's named for the capybaras that frequent the waterways, and you'll almost certainly see them.

Note: access to Chapada Imperial may require coordination with the reserve administration. Check current conditions and access procedures before visiting.

Leveling Up: From Intermediate to Advanced

If you've ridden these trails and you're hungry for more, you're ready for Chapter 8. But before you turn the page, a word of honesty:

The gap between intermediate and advanced in Brasília is real. Intermediate trails challenge your fitness and introduce technical features. Advanced trails challenge everything — fitness, skill, mental toughness, navigation, and your ability to be self-sufficient for hours in remote terrain.

Make sure you can comfortably complete Catingueiro (27 km, 550m climbing) without bonking, clear the creek crossings on Trilha 3 Riachos without dismounting, and handle the rocky sections on Chapada Imperial before moving on.

If you can? You're going to love what comes next.

Chapter 8: Trail Guide — Advanced Trails



Technical root section on an advanced trail — where skill meets
the raw cerrado

This chapter has a warning.

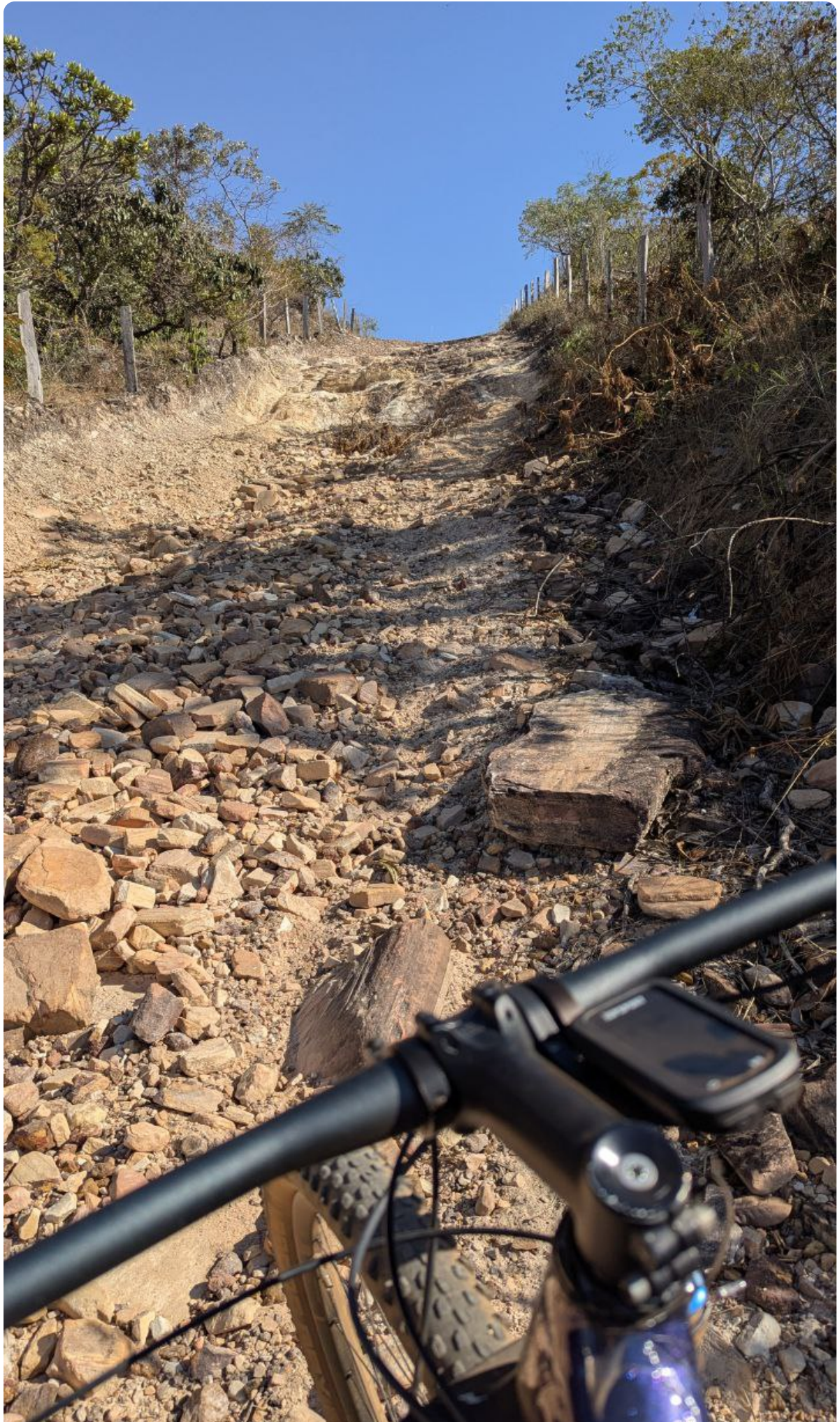
The trails in the previous two chapters will test you. The trails in this chapter will break you — in the best possible way. These are long, remote, physically demanding routes through Brasília's wildest terrain. They involve sustained climbing, technical descents, route-finding in areas with limited signage, and the kind of commitment that means once you're in, turning back is often harder than pushing forward.

They are also, without question, the most rewarding rides in the Distrito Federal.

These are the rides that made me a mountain biker. Not the easy loops, not the scenic cruises — these. The rides where you start before dawn and finish as the sun sets. Where you question your life choices at kilometer 30 and celebrate your existence at kilometer 40. Where the cerrado reveals its deepest beauty because you earned the right to see it.

If you're ready, let's go.

Trail 12: Córrego do Ouro — The Gold Standard



POV on a rocky technical climb — Córrego do Ouro demands
everything you've got

Distance: 48 km

Elevation Gain: ~980m

Difficulty: Advanced

Time: 3-4 hours (strong riders); 4-6 hours (most riders)

Surface: Rocky singletrack, dirt road, steep climbs and descents, creek crossings

Water: Creek crossings (not reliably potable); bring 3+ liters

Trailhead GPS: CIPLAN factory area, Fercal (-15.56, -47.90 approx.)

Best Season: May-September only (sections impassable in heavy rains)

Highlights: Dramatic limestone terrain, Fercal valley views, full-day adventure

André's Rating: [★★★★] — The ride that defines Brasília mountain biking

The Ride

Córrego do Ouro — "Gold Creek" — starts at the CIPLAN cement factory in Fercal and proceeds to systematically destroy your legs while filling your soul.

This is my home trail, and after dozens of rides, it still humbles me.

The route climbs out of the Fercal valley through limestone terrain that is unlike anything else in the DF. The rocks here are sharp, white, and relentless — the descents demand constant attention to line choice, and the climbs are steep enough that you'll be grinding in your lowest gear or walking. There's no shame in it. I still walk one section that we call o

muro (the wall) — a 200-meter pitch that averages 15% gradient over loose rock.

But the payoff. Meu Deus, the payoff.

The views from the limestone ridges over the Fercal valley are cinematic. On a clear dry-season morning, you can see the Congresso Nacional and the Esplanada dos Ministérios glinting in the distance. The cerrado around you shifts between dense cerradão in the valleys and sparse, wind-blown campo rupestre (rocky field vegetation) on the ridges. There's a section around kilometer 25 where the trail follows a limestone cliff edge with a 50-meter drop to your left and the cerrado valley stretching to infinity on your right. It's terrifying and magnificent.

The 48 kilometers accumulate almost 1,000 meters of elevation gain, but it's the terrain quality rather than the raw numbers that makes this trail advanced. The rocks are technical, the route-finding requires attention (not as well-signposted as FLONA), and the remoteness means help is far away if something goes wrong.

André's Tip: Córrego do Ouro is best ridden with a group of 3-5 experienced riders who know the route. I don't recommend it for solo riders unfamiliar with the trail — GPS tracks from Wikiloc are essential, but the route has variations that can be confusing. Join a Rebas do Cerrado group ride for your first attempt. They run this trail regularly and know every rock, every turn, and every place where newbies get lost.

Trail 13: Trilha Pé D'Serra — The Century Ride

Distance: 100 km

Elevation Gain: ~1,800m

Difficulty: Advanced+

Time: 6-10 hours

Surface: Dirt road, rocky trail, singletrack, farm roads, some pavement

Water: Limited — plan water stops; carry 3+ liters and know resupply points

Trailhead GPS: Brazlândia region (-15.68, -48.18 approx.)

Best Season: June-September only

Highlights: Epic distance, Serra de Brazlândia, complete cerrado traverse

André's Rating: [★★★★] — A life-list ride

The Ride

One hundred kilometers. On dirt. In the cerrado.

Trilha Pé D'Serra ("Foot of the Mountain Trail") is an absolute monster — a full-day expedition around the Brazlândia region, west of Brasília proper. This is not a trail you decide to ride on a whim. It requires planning, fitness, self-sufficiency, and the mental toughness to keep pedaling when every part of your body wants to stop.

The route circumnavigates the Serra de Brazlândia, passing through some of the most remote and untouched cerrado in the Distrito Federal. You'll ride through rural communities, cross multiple streams, climb

steep mountain tracks, and traverse stretches where you won't see another person for an hour or more. The terrain shifts between rutted farm roads, smooth dirt double-track, and sections of genuine singletrack that wind through dense vegetation.

The climbing is relentless. 1,800 meters over 100 kilometers doesn't sound extreme on paper, but there's no single long climb to suffer through and forget — it's constant undulations, short steep pitches, and grinding false flats that eat your energy. Nutrition and hydration management become critical survival skills.

I've done this ride twice. The first time, I bonked at kilometer 70, crawled the last 30 kilometers, and swore I'd never do it again. The second time, I managed my nutrition properly, rode with a strong group, and finished feeling like I could conquer the world.

Both times were the best rides of my year.

André's Tip: For Pé D'Serra, preparation is everything. Study the GPS track beforehand and identify water resupply points — some farms and vendas (small shops) along the route sell water and snacks, but you need to know where they are. Carry a minimum of 3 liters of water plus electrolytes, enough food for 8+ hours, a complete repair kit, and a charged phone with offline maps. Start at first light. Tell multiple people your route and expected return time. This is expedition-level riding.

Trail 14: Trilha União — The Great Connector

Distance: 45 km (standalone) / 136 km (full circuit)

Elevation Gain: ~800m (standalone)

Difficulty: Advanced

Time: 4-6 hours (standalone); 10-14 hours (full circuit)

Surface: Singletrack, dirt road, technical sections

Water: Creek crossings; plan carefully

Trailhead GPS: Multiple access points — common start at FLONA

Best Season: May-September

Highlights: Part of Brazil's largest MTB circuit, connects FLONA to Serrinha do Paranoá

André's Rating: ☐☐☐☐☐ — The ride that puts Brasília on the map

The Ride

Here's a sentence I never get tired of writing: **Trilha União is part of the largest mountain biking circuit in Brazil.**

The full circuit — 136 kilometers connecting FLONA, Trilha União, and Serrinha do Paranoá — is a complete traverse of the Distrito Federal's trail systems. Most riders break it into sections, and Trilha União (45 km) is the crown jewel.

The trail's name means "Union Trail," and it lives up to it — this route connects different ecosystems, different communities, and different trail networks into one grand narrative. You'll ride through deep cerrado,

cross agricultural areas, traverse veredas (palm groves), and climb to viewpoints that reveal the full scope of Brasília's landscape.

The terrain is varied and demanding. Sections of fast, flowing singletrack alternate with technical climbs, rocky descents, and river crossings that may require wading. Navigation requires attention — some sections are less well-marked than FLONA, and GPS is essential.

But the feeling of riding Trilha União — of being on a trail that connects an entire biome, that represents years of community trail-building effort, that traverses the capital's backcountry from one side to the other — is unlike anything else in Brazilian mountain biking.

The full 136-kilometer circuit is typically ridden as a multi-day adventure or by ultra-endurance riders in a single push. Either way, it's a statement ride — the kind of thing you train for, plan for, and remember forever.

André's Tip: If the full 136 km circuit intimidates you (it should), start with a supported section. Several local groups organize annual group rides of the full circuit, with SAG vehicles, water stops, and mechanical support. It's the best way to experience the route without the solo-expedition pressure. Check Rebas do Cerrado's calendar.

Trail 15: Serra da Contagem — Technical Paradise

Distance: 25-35 km (various routes)

Elevation Gain: 600-900m

Difficulty: Advanced

Time: 3-5 hours

Surface: Rocky singletrack, exposed rock slabs, steep terrain

Water: Streams in valleys; carry your own

Trailhead GPS: Various access points along the Serra da Contagem

Best Season: May-September

Highlights: Most technical terrain in the DF, rock gardens, exposed riding

André's Rating: ☐☐☐☐ — Pure technical riding — bring your skills

The Ride

If Córrego do Ouro is the complete Brasília experience, Serra da Contagem is its technical distillation. This mountain range just outside the urban area offers the most technically demanding terrain in the DF — steep gradients, exposed rock slabs, tight switchbacks through dense vegetation, and descents that demand absolute precision.

The trails here climb through altitude zones of cerrado, from cerradão forest at the base to campo rupestre (rocky highland) near the summits. The rock is quartzite — sharper and more abrasive than FLONA's sandstone, harder on tires, and less forgiving of crashes.

Routes on the Serra vary from 25 to 35 kilometers, with the longer options involving significant traverses along the ridgeline. The views from the top — across the DF to the north and west, with the urban skyline visible to the south — are extraordinary.

This is a trail for riders who love the challenge of reading terrain, choosing lines, and dancing their bike through rock gardens. If your idea of fun is a smooth dirt road, look elsewhere. If your idea of fun is a ten-meter rock slab at 20% gradient with a drop on one side — welcome home.

The Mental Game

Before I close this chapter, I want to talk about something that doesn't get enough attention: the mental challenge of advanced riding.

A 48-kilometer ride through remote terrain takes 4-6 hours. That's 4-6 hours of decision-making, physical output, and environmental awareness. At some point — usually around hour three, when the glycogen is depleted and the sun is high — your brain starts whispering things:

This was a stupid idea.

You should have turned back at the last junction.

Your knee is definitely injured.

You're going to be out here forever.

This is normal. It happens to every rider on every hard ride. The voice is your brain's survival instinct trying to protect you from voluntary suffering. The trick is to acknowledge it without obeying it.

Eat something. Drink water. Look around at where you are. Remember that discomfort is temporary but the memory of finishing this ride will last forever. Then put your head down and keep pedaling.

The cerrado doesn't reward quitters. It rewards the stubborn, the patient, and the slightly crazy.

You're reading the advanced chapter. You're one of us.

Vamos que vamos. (Let's keep going.)

Chapter 9: Riding Brasília's National Park & FLONA



Muddy bike on a forest bridge deep in FLONA — where the
cerrado meets the wild

If Brasília's trail system is a kingdom, FLONA is the throne.

The Floresta Nacional de Brasília — the Brasília National Forest, universally known as FLONA — is the single most important mountain biking destination in the Distrito Federal. It's where beginners take their first pedal strokes on dirt. It's where intermediates discover what singletrack really means. It's where advanced riders train for races and test their limits. And it's where every rider, regardless of level, goes to remember why they fell in love with this sport.

I've ridden in FLONA at least a hundred times. I've seen it in every season, every light, every mood. I've watched the sun rise over its cerrado ridges and set behind its gallery forests. I've been caught in thunderstorms on its trails and baked in dry-season heat on its fire roads.

It never gets old.

This chapter is a deep dive into everything FLONA offers: its history, its trail system, its ecology, and the practical information you need to make the most of every visit.

What Is FLONA?

FLONA is a Floresta Nacional — a national forest managed by ICMBio (the Chico Mendes Institute for Biodiversity Conservation), Brazil's federal environmental agency. It was created in 1999, covering approximately 9,346 hectares of cerrado in the northwestern part of the Distrito Federal.

Unlike a national park, which is primarily for preservation, a national forest allows sustainable use of natural resources — including recreational activities like mountain biking. This distinction is crucial: it means FLONA was designed from the beginning to accommodate human activity in balance with conservation.

The mountain biking infrastructure in FLONA is the result of years of collaboration between ICMBio, local riding groups (especially Rebas do Cerrado), and government agencies. The result is remarkable: **the largest signalized mountain biking trail system in a conservation unit in all of Brazil.**

Let that sink in. The largest. In the country.

Access: Free. Open daily. No registration required for individual riders. Group events may require prior coordination with ICMBio.

The Seven Routes

FLONA's trail system consists of seven official routes, progressing from beginner to advanced. Each route is color-coded, signposted, and mapped with QR codes that link to GPS tracks.

Rota 1 — Circuito Iniciante (Beginner Circuit)

Distance: 5 km | **Elevation:** ~80m | **Difficulty:** ☐ Easy

The gentle introduction. Wide fire roads, minimal climbing, professional signage. Covered in Chapter 6. Perfect for first-timers and families.

Rota 2 — Circuito Básico (Basic Circuit)

Distance: 12 km | **Elevation:** ~180m | **Difficulty:** ☐ Easy-Moderate

The step up. Introduces narrower trails and longer distances. Covered in Chapter 6. The ride that hooks beginners into becoming regular riders.

Rota 3 — Circuito Intermediário (Intermediate Circuit)

Distance: 18 km | **Elevation:** ~300m | **Difficulty:** ☐ Moderate

Where things get interesting. Genuine singletrack, creek crossings, and the first taste of cerrado climbing. Varied terrain keeps it engaging. Covered in Chapter 7.

Rota 4 — Circuito Trilha do Vale (Valley Trail Circuit)

Distance: 22 km | **Elevation:** ~380m | **Difficulty:** □ Moderate

My personal favorite. Ridge riding, deep valley descent into gallery forest, the most beautiful creek section in FLONA, and a climb back out that earns its reputation. Covered in Chapter 7.

Rota 5 — Circuito das Nascentes (Springs Circuit)

Distance: 28 km | **Elevation:** ~500m | **Difficulty:** □ Moderate-Hard

Named for the natural springs it passes, this route takes you into the more remote areas of FLONA. The trail passes through multiple headwater areas — the source of streams that eventually feed into Lago Paranoá. Ecologically fascinating and physically demanding.

Rota 6 — Circuito Avançado (Advanced Circuit)

Distance: 36 km | **Elevation:** ~700m | **Difficulty:** □ Hard

The serious route. Long sustained climbs, technical descents, remote sections with limited signage, and enough distance that you'd better have your nutrition dialed. This is training-grade riding.

Rota 7 — Circuito Completo (Complete Circuit)

Distance: 44 km | **Elevation:** ~900m | **Difficulty:** □□ Hard-Expert

The big one. FLONA's longest route links together the best sections of all previous routes into a single grand tour of the forest. At 44

kilometers with nearly 1,000 meters of climbing, it's a half-day adventure that demands real fitness and preparation.

Rota 7 is my test-piece ride. When I want to know where my fitness stands, I ride Rota 7 and see how I feel at the end. On a good day, it's a three-hour masterpiece. On a bad day, it's a five-hour sufferfest. Both versions are worth it.

André's Tip: Don't try to jump straight to Rota 7. Work through the routes in order — each one prepares you for the next. Spend at least 3-4 rides on the intermediate routes (3-5) before attempting Rota 6 or 7. Your body will thank you, and you'll enjoy the longer routes much more with a fitness base under you.

The Ecology of FLONA

FLONA isn't just a trail system — it's a conservation area, and riding through it responsibly means understanding what you're riding through.

Flora

The forest encompasses several cerrado vegetation types:

Cerrado sentido restrito — The dominant vegetation type. Twisted trees (3-8 meters tall) with thick, corky bark adapted to survive fire. The pau-terra, barbatimão, and pequi trees are the signature species. The pequi tree is particularly important culturally — its fruit is a cerrado delicacy, and during pequi season (November-February), you'll see locals collecting fruit near the trails.

Mata de galeria — The gallery forests that line every stream. These are biodiversity hotspots — more species per square meter than the surrounding cerrado. Riding through them is like entering a different

world: the temperature drops, the humidity rises, and the canopy closes overhead.

Campo limpo and campo sujo — Open grasslands on ridges and hilltops. These are the viewpoint areas — when the trees thin out and the sky opens up, stop and look around.

Vereda — Palm-dominated wetlands centered on the buriti palm. You'll see these in low-lying areas near the springs. They're fragile ecosystems — stay on the trail and don't ride through them.

Fauna

FLONA is one of the best places in the DF to see cerrado wildlife from the saddle:

- **Capybaras** near creek crossings (common)
- **Giant anteaters** (tamanduá-bandeira) in open cerrado (occasional — and unforgettable)
- **Toucans** and **macaws** in gallery forest (common)
- **Rheas** (emas) — large flightless birds in open areas (occasional)
- **Armadillos** (tatus) on the trail, usually scurrying away (common at dawn)
- **Maned wolves** (lobos-guará) at dawn or dusk (rare but possible)

Trail etiquette with wildlife: Slow down when you see animals. Don't chase, approach, or try to touch them. Give them right of way. Turn off your speaker/music. The animals tolerate riders because we're respectful. Keep it that way.

André's Tip: The best wildlife viewing in FLONA is at dawn — arrive at the trailhead by 5:30 AM and start riding at first light. I've seen maned wolves, giant anteaters, and deer in the first hour

of the morning. By mid-morning, most animals retreat into the vegetation.

Practical Information

Getting There

FLONA's main access point is on the DF-001 road, near Lago Oeste. From Brasília's Plano Piloto, it's approximately 25-30 minutes by car. The road is paved all the way.

If you're staying in Lago Norte, Sobradinho, or Grande Colorado, the drive is even shorter — 15-20 minutes.

Parking is available at the main trailhead. It's free but can fill up on weekend mornings. Arrive early.

Some riders ride to FLONA from their homes — depending on where you live, the approach ride can add 10-30 kilometers to your total.

Best Time to Visit

Dry season (May-September): Prime time. Hard-packed trails, no mud, predictable weather, cool mornings. This is when FLONA is at its best for riding.

Transition months (April, October): Good riding with occasional rain. The cerrado is transitioning — still mostly dry but with the first green shoots appearing.

Rainy season (November-March): Rideable but challenging. Some sections become muddy, creek crossings are higher, and afternoon storms are common. Start early and plan to finish before 2:00 PM.

Combining Routes

One of FLONA's best features is route modularity. Because the routes share many trail sections, you can easily create custom loops:

- **Short morning ride:** Rota 3 outbound, return on Rota 2 (15 km)
- **Classic half-day:** Rota 4 + sections of Rota 5 (25 km)
- **Full day with variety:** Rota 7 with detours onto Rota 5's spring sections (50+ km)

Download the routes to your GPS device before riding and experiment with combinations. The signage makes it easy to navigate between routes.

Rules and Respect

- Stay on marked trails
- Do not ride through veredas (palm wetlands)
- Pack out all trash
- Yield to pedestrians and equestrians
- No motorized vehicles
- No harvesting plants or disturbing wildlife
- Respect seasonal closures (some sections may be closed during fire season)

Parque Nacional de Brasília — A Note

The Parque Nacional de Brasília (Brasília National Park) is a separate entity from FLONA. While the national park — famous for its piscinas (swimming pools) fed by natural springs — is a beloved recreational area, **mountain biking access within the national park itself is limited and regulated differently than FLONA.**

The national park covers over 42,000 hectares and has hiking trails, but most are not open to bikes. Check with ICMBio for current regulations before planning a ride within the national park boundaries.

When Brasília riders refer to riding "in the park," they almost always mean FLONA, not the national park proper. This distinction matters — plan accordingly.

FLONA as a Way of Life

I want to close this chapter with something personal.

FLONA is where I rebuilt myself.

I came back to Brazil carrying the weight of sixteen years abroad — the stress, the displacement, the sense of not quite belonging anywhere. In those first months in Brasília, when everything felt unfamiliar and overwhelming, FLONA was my anchor.

I'd ride into the forest before dawn, when the air was cool and the birds were waking up. The trail would narrow, the city would disappear, and it was just me and the cerrado. The rhythm of pedaling. The sound of tires on red dirt. The smell of barbatimão bark in the morning sun.

Hour by hour, ride by ride, FLONA gave me back something I'd lost. Not just fitness — though that came. It gave me a sense of place. A sense of belonging. A home.

I think that's what the best trails do. They don't just challenge your body. They welcome your soul.

FLONA welcomed mine. It'll welcome yours too.

Chapter 10: Day Trips & Beyond

— Chapada dos Veadeiros, Pirenópolis & Alto Paraíso



A hidden waterfall pool in the cerrado — the ultimate reward at
the end of every ride

At some point, Brasília's trails won't be enough.

Not because they stop being good — they never stop being good. But because the riding bug bites deep, and you start looking at the map and thinking: What's out there?

The answer: some of the most spectacular riding terrain in South America, all within a few hours' drive of your doorstep.

Brasília sits at the center of the Planalto Central like a hub in a wheel, and the spokes lead to places that'll make your jaw drop. Ancient canyon lands. Mountain towns with colonial architecture. Waterfalls that look like they were designed for fantasy films. And trails — oh, the trails.

This chapter covers the destinations I go to when I want to expand my horizons. Each one is doable as a day trip or a weekend adventure from Brasília.

Chapada dos Veadeiros



A cyclist at a dramatic cerrado waterfall — nature's encore after hours on the trail

Distance from Brasília: ~230 km (3-3.5 hours by car)

Best for: Multi-day adventure, advanced riding, otherworldly scenery

Best season: May-September (dry season)

Base town: Alto Paraíso de Goiás or São Jorge

Why Go

Chapada dos Veadeiros is one of Brazil's most dramatic natural landscapes — a UNESCO World Heritage Site of ancient quartzite plateaus, deep canyons, towering waterfalls, and cerrado vegetation

that's been growing on some of the oldest exposed rock on Earth (1.8 billion years old).

The mountain biking here is raw, wild, and entirely different from Brasília's organized trail systems. You're riding through a landscape that makes you feel like an explorer — because, in many ways, you are. Some of these trails are lightly traveled, poorly marked, and require genuine route-finding skills.

The Rides

Trilha dos Saltos — A classic route that visits a series of spectacular waterfalls, including the 120-meter Salto do Rio Preto. The riding involves a mix of rocky trails and fire roads through high cerrado. Technical, scenic, unforgettable.

Trilha dos Cânions — A demanding route along the canyon edges with sections of exposed riding and stunning vertigo-inducing views. For experienced riders with a head for heights.

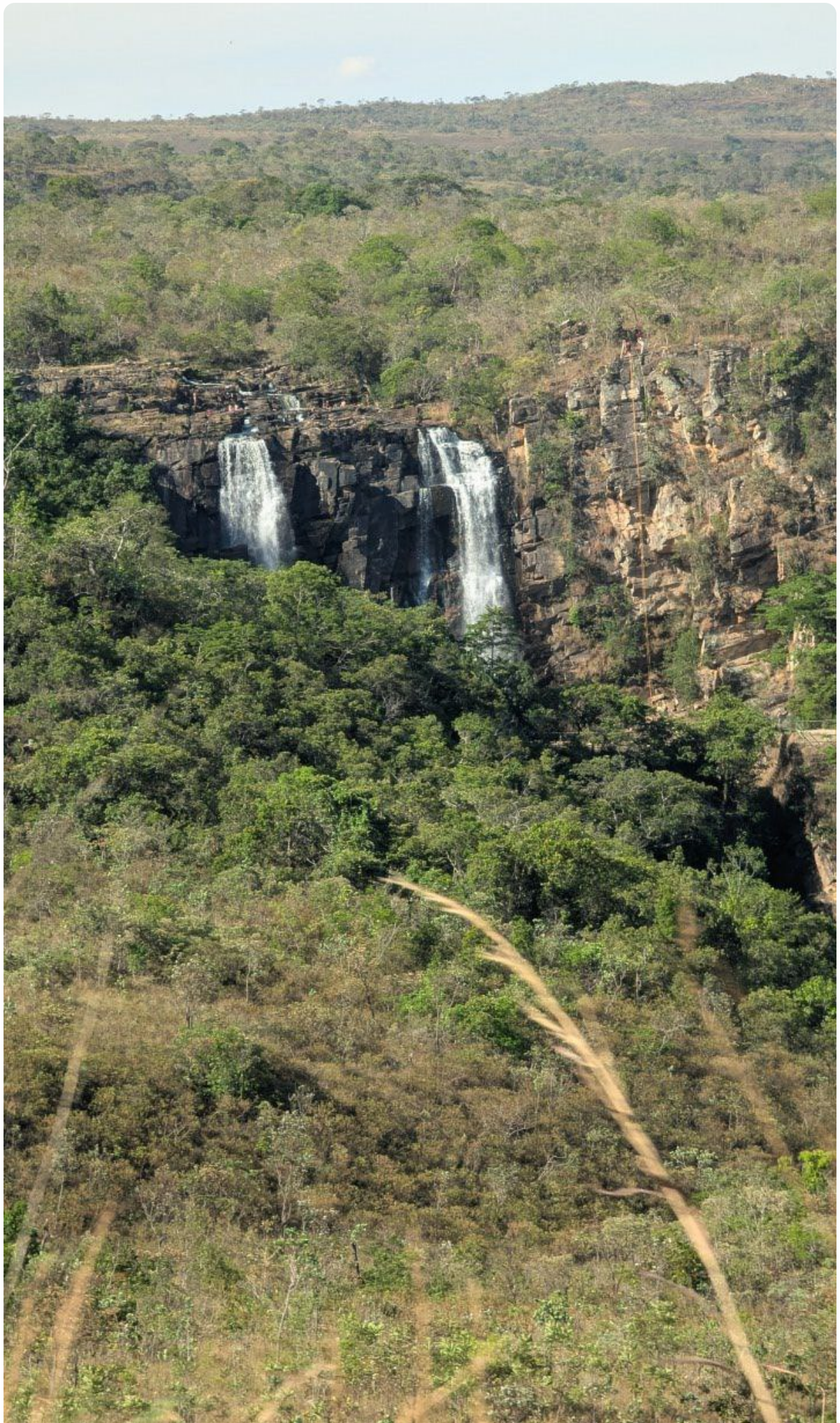
Alto Paraíso to São Jorge — The road between these two towns (roughly 35 km) can be ridden on bike via a mix of pavement and dirt roads through rolling cerrado. It's a beautiful approach ride, and São Jorge — a tiny village at the park entrance — has hostels, restaurants, and the atmosphere of a place that exists entirely because of the natural world around it.

Community-organized rides: Local guides and riding groups in Alto Paraíso offer guided MTB trips that access private properties and trails not available to independent riders. These are often the best way to experience the area's riding, and guides provide critical local knowledge about trail conditions and navigation.

André's Tip: Chapada dos Veadeiros deserves at least a weekend, not a day trip. Drive up Friday evening, ride Saturday and Sunday,

drive back Sunday night. Stay in Alto Paraíso (more infrastructure, restaurants, shops) or São Jorge (more atmosphere, closer to the park). Book accommodation in advance during holiday weekends — the Chapada is a popular destination for Brasilienses escaping the city.

Pirenópolis



Twin waterfall cascading through the cerrado — a day trip
destination worth every kilometer

Distance from Brasília: ~150 km (2-2.5 hours by car)

Best for: Weekend trip, intermediate to advanced riding, culture + trails

Best season: May-September

Base town: Pirenópolis

Why Go

Piri, as everyone calls it, is a colonial mining town in Goiás state that has reinvented itself as an ecotourism and adventure sports destination. The town itself is charming — stone streets, colorful colonial buildings, excellent restaurants, a lively praça (town square) with live music on weekends. The riding in the surrounding Serra dos Pirineus is exceptional.

The Rides

Serra dos Pirineus State Park — The state park offers several trails through cerrado and mata atlântica (Atlantic forest) transition zones, with the Pico dos Pirineus (1,385m) as the ultimate destination. The climb to the peak is a grinding, technical affair on rocky trails, rewarded by 360-degree views that encompass the entire central Goiás landscape.

Waterfall circuits — Pirenópolis is famous for its waterfalls, and several can be linked into riding circuits. The Cachoeira do Rosário, Cachoeira da Usina, and Cachoeira do Abade are all accessible via rideable trails or dirt roads from town. Some require entry fees at private properties.

Rural circuits — The dirt roads around Pirenópolis wind through fazendas (farms), cerrado remnants, and small communities. A 40-60 km

loop can be designed from town with help from local guides or Wikiloc tracks. The terrain is rolling, the scenery is pastoral, and the pace is gentle.

Beyond the Bike

Pirenópolis is the kind of place where the non-riding activities are as good as the riding. The restaurants serve excellent comida goiana (Goiás cuisine) — empadão goiano (savory pie), pamonha (sweet corn paste), and arroz com pequi (rice with pequi fruit, the cerrado's most distinctive flavor). The waterfalls are perfect for swimming after a ride. And the town's Festa do Divino (May/June) is one of the most colorful cultural festivals in central Brazil.

André's Tip: Pirenópolis is my go-to recovery weekend. After a particularly brutal training block, I drive to Piri on Friday, do a moderate scenic ride on Saturday, swim in a waterfall, eat absurd amounts of empadão, and drive home Sunday feeling human again. It's the perfect balance of adventure and rest.

Alto Paraíso de Goiás & Vale da Lua

Distance from Brasília: ~220 km (3 hours by car)

Best for: Weekend trip, mixed riding, spiritual/mystical atmosphere

Best season: May-September

Why Go

Alto Paraíso is the gateway to Chapada dos Veadeiros (covered above), but it deserves its own mention because the town and immediate surroundings offer a distinct riding experience.

Alto Paraíso has a reputation as a spiritual and alternative community — crystals, meditation centers, organic restaurants, and an atmosphere that's decidedly different from Brasília's bureaucratic energy. The riding in the immediate area is less extreme than deeper in the Chapada but still excellent.

The Rides

Vale da Lua — The "Valley of the Moon" is one of Brazil's most extraordinary geological formations: quartzite rock sculpted by millions of years of water erosion into bizarre, lunar shapes. The ride to Vale da Lua from Alto Paraíso is approximately 25 km on mixed terrain, and the destination is worth every kilometer. You'll walk the final section to the formations (bikes not allowed in the geological area itself).

Povoado de São Jorge circuits — From the village of São Jorge, several dirt road and trail circuits explore the cerrado surrounding the national park. Distances range from 15-50 km depending on the route.

Cavalcante direction — The road toward Cavalcante (north of Alto Paraíso) passes through increasingly remote cerrado with access to the

Quilombola (Afro-Brazilian) community of Kalunga, one of the most important cultural sites in central Brazil. The riding is mostly on dirt roads, and the cultural experience is profound.

Sertão Diamante Region

Distance from Brasília: ~200-300 km (varies by specific destination)

Best for: Multi-day expedition, advanced riders, true backcountry

Best season: June-August only

Why Go

The Sertão Diamante (Diamond Backcountry) refers to the semi-arid cerrado regions to the north and northeast of Brasília, historically mined for diamonds. The landscape is harsh, beautiful, and empty — sparsely populated, poorly roaded, and offering the kind of riding that makes you feel like the only person on Earth.

The annual Sertão Diamante event (covered in Chapter 12) traverses this region, but it can also be explored independently with proper preparation.

The Rides

This is expedition territory. You need to be self-sufficient, carry your own water (sources can be unreliable), navigate by GPS, and be prepared for long stretches without cell service or civilization. Routes of 50-100+ km per day on dirt roads and trails through some of the most pristine cerrado in central Brazil.

Not for the faint of heart. Absolutely for the adventurous of spirit.

André's Tip: For Sertão Diamante exploration outside of organized events, go with a group of at least 3-4 experienced riders, and ideally with vehicle support. Carry 5+ liters of water per person, complete repair kits, first aid supplies, and a satellite

communicator (Garmin inReach or similar). This is beautiful but remote country — respect it.

Planning Your Trip

The Weekend Template

For any of these destinations, here's the template that works:

Friday evening: Drive from Brasília after work (2-3.5 hours depending on destination). Check into accommodation. Light dinner. Sleep early.

Saturday: Full day of riding. Start early (6-7 AM), ride the primary route, swim in a waterfall, eat lunch. Optional short afternoon ride or rest.

Sunday: Moderate morning ride or exploration. Pack up. Drive back to Brasília by early afternoon.

What to Bring (Beyond Normal Ride Gear)

- Full change of clothes
- Towel and swimsuit (waterfalls!)
- Cash (small towns may have limited card acceptance)
- Physical map or downloaded offline GPS for the region
- First aid kit suitable for remote travel
- Vehicle emergency kit (spare tire, jump cables, etc.)
- Cooler with drinks and snacks for the drive

Vehicle Considerations

Most destinations are accessible with a standard car on paved roads. However, some specific trailheads — particularly in Chapada dos Veadeiros and Sertão Diamante — require high-clearance vehicles or

4WD on dirt roads. Check conditions before driving to remote trailheads, especially in the rainy season.

A bike rack is essential. Roof racks work but add height (watch for low branches on farm roads). Trunk/hitch-mounted racks are more convenient. If you don't own a rack, consider renting one from a bike shop in Brasília.

The Expanding Horizon

These destinations are the ones I know best, but they're not the only options. The cerrado around Brasília is vast, and new riding areas are being explored constantly. Cavalcante, Niquelândia, Cristalina, Formosa — each direction from the capital offers different terrain, different challenges, different beauty.

The longer you ride in Brasília, the wider your circle of exploration becomes. First FLONA, then the DF's outer trails, then the surrounding states. Before you know it, you've got a map on your wall with pins marking every place your bike has taken you, and you're planning rides that would have seemed impossible a year ago.

That's the magic of this sport. The bike is a vehicle, literally and figuratively, for expanding your world.

Keep expanding.

Part IV: The Culture

Chapter 11: The Mountain Biking Community



Utopia Bike Club DF — the community that makes Brasília's
MTB scene unlike anywhere else

You can ride alone. The trails don't require company. Some of my best rides have been solo — just me, the cerrado, and the sound of my own breathing.

But here's the truth: the community is why I stayed.

Not the trails, not the climate, not the sunsets. Those are all extraordinary. But I could find good trails elsewhere. What I couldn't find — what I've never found anywhere else in the world — is a riding community this warm, this welcoming, this genuinely happy to see you show up.

Brazilian cycling culture is built on *convivência* — the art of living together, of sharing experience, of turning strangers into friends and friends into family through the simple act of riding bikes. And Brasília's MTB community practices this art with a generosity that still catches me off guard, even after years of riding here.

This chapter is about the people. Because in the end, that's what it's really about.

Rebas do Cerrado: The Backbone

If you spend any time in Brasília's mountain biking scene, you'll hear one name constantly: Rebas do Cerrado.

Rebas (short for *rebas*, a colloquial term for a group ride or outing) is the primary mountain biking community organization in the DF. But calling them an "organization" undersells what they actually are. They're trail builders, route mappers, event organizers, community builders, and the *de facto* custodians of Brasília's trail culture.

What they do:

- **Trail maintenance:** Regular mutirões (volunteer work parties) to clear trails, repair signage, and maintain the infrastructure that makes Brasília's trail system function.
- **Route documentation:** Detailed GPS tracks, difficulty ratings, and trail descriptions published at **pedal.rebas.com.br** — the definitive online resource for Brasília riding.
- **Group rides:** Organized rides ranging from beginner-friendly pedaladinhas (little rides) to full-send advanced adventures. Multiple rides per week, open to anyone.
- **Community events:** Social rides, trail cleanups, skill clinics, and collaborations with government agencies on trail policy.
- **Advocacy:** Working with ICMBio, the DF government, and private landowners to secure and expand legal trail access.

The people behind Rebas are volunteers — riders who love these trails and put in hundreds of hours of unpaid work to keep them accessible and maintained. They are the reason FLONA's signage is impeccable, the reason Wikiloc is loaded with GPS tracks, and the reason you can show up at a trailhead as a complete stranger and ride home with ten new friends.

André's Tip: Your first step in Brasília's MTB community should be visiting **pedal.rebas.com.br** and following Rebas do Cerrado on Instagram. Their website has detailed trail guides with GPS tracks for most major routes in the DF. Their social media announces upcoming group rides, events, and trail conditions. Bookmark both. Use both.

Group Ride Culture



The world through a wheel — community, trails, and the cerrado
beyond

Group rides in Brasília are a phenomenon. Not the silent, competitive, no-eye-contact affairs you might know from road cycling. These are social events that happen to involve bikes.

How It Works

Most group rides follow a pattern:

The concentração (gathering point): Riders meet at a designated location — a trailhead, a gas station, a parking lot. This is where you arrive early, set up your bike, chat with people, and figure out who's

who. There's always coffee. Sometimes pão de queijo. Always conversation.

The briefing: The ride leader (usually an experienced local) explains the route, distance, difficulty, and any hazards. They'll ask about experience levels and make sure beginners are paired with experienced riders.

The ride: The group sets off together but quickly stratifies by speed. Faster riders push ahead; slower riders find their rhythm. At every major junction, the front group waits for the back group. **Nobody gets left behind.** This is the cardinal rule of Brasília group rides.

The parada (stop): Mid-ride stops at viewpoints, creek crossings, or shade trees. Water breaks, snack sharing, photo ops. This is where conversations happen — where you learn about new trails, upcoming events, and get invited to rides you didn't know existed.

The retorno (return): The group reconvenes for the ride back. The pace often mellows as fatigue sets in and the social aspect takes over.

The after-ride: Arguably the best part. Post-ride gatherings at a lanchonete (snack bar), a padaria (bakery), or someone's house. Cold guaraná, pastéis, caldo de cana, cerveja (beer) if it's late enough. Stories about the ride, the crash everyone saw, the view nobody got a photo of. This is where friendships are made.

The Unwritten Rules

Show up on time. The concentração has a departure time. Respect it. Arriving late makes the whole group wait.

Be honest about your fitness. If you're a beginner, say so. Nobody will judge you, but they need to know so they can adjust the pace and keep you safe. What WILL get you judged is claiming to be intermediate and then bonking at kilometer 10, holding up everyone.

Don't half-wheel. Riding just slightly ahead of the person next to you, making them constantly speed up. It's unconscious and annoying. Ride at the group's pace or officially pull ahead.

Share your food. Rapadura, bananas, energy bars — if you have extra, offer it around. This is Brazil. We share.

Thank the ride leader. Organizing a group ride is work. GPS planning, WhatsApp coordination, showing up early, knowing the route, managing different fitness levels. A simple "Valeu, cara" (Thanks, dude) at the end goes a long way.

Women in Brasília's MTB Scene

One of the most exciting developments in Brasília's mountain biking community is the growth of women's riding.

Historically, mountain biking in Brazil — like most of the world — was heavily male-dominated. Women who wanted to ride often felt unwelcome, unsafe, or simply unseen in mixed groups. That's changing fast.

Several women's riding groups have emerged in Brasília, offering rides specifically by and for women. These groups provide:

- **A safe and supportive environment** for women of all levels
- **Skills-specific coaching** addressing techniques and confidence
- **Community building** among women who share a passion for the sport
- **Representation** that inspires other women to try mountain biking

The growth has been dramatic. Where women once made up 5-10% of a group ride, some weekend rides now see 30-40% female participation. Women's categories in local races are growing, and female riders are

increasingly visible as ride leaders, trail advocates, and community organizers.

If you're a woman interested in mountain biking in Brasília, seek out these groups through Instagram and WhatsApp. The community is eager to welcome you.

André's Tip: I've learned more about good riding from following experienced women riders than from most male riders. Women tend to ride with more precision, better body positioning, and smarter line choices — compensating for raw power with technique. Watch and learn.

How to Plug In

If you're new to Brasília and want to join the community, here's your roadmap:

Step 1: Online First

- Follow **Rebas do Cerrado** on Instagram and visit pedal.rebas.com.br
- Search Facebook for "MTB Brasília" groups — several active communities
- Download Strava and follow local riders — Brasília's Strava community is active, and local riders regularly post routes and invitations

Step 2: Show Up

- Find a beginner-friendly group ride through any of the above channels
- Show up at the concentração 15 minutes early

- Introduce yourself. Say you're new. People will flock to you — Brazilians love welcoming newcomers

Step 3: Ride Consistently

- Come back the next week. And the next. Consistency builds relationships
- Within a month, you'll be in WhatsApp groups, invited to churrascos, and given a trail nickname

Step 4: Give Back

- Join a trail maintenance mutirão
- Share your GPS tracks
- Help a newer rider the way someone helped you
- The circle of generosity is what keeps the community alive

WhatsApp: The Social Hub

In Brazil, WhatsApp isn't just a messaging app — it's the social operating system. And Brasília's MTB community runs on it.

Every riding group, every event organizer, every bike shop, and every informal crew of friends has a WhatsApp group. Ride invitations, trail conditions, weather reports, gear for sale, mechanic recommendations, crash photos, and post-ride memes — it all flows through WhatsApp.

The downside: your phone will buzz constantly once you join a few MTB WhatsApp groups. The volume of messages can be overwhelming. Learn to mute groups that are too chatty and set notification preferences.

The upside: you'll never miss a ride invitation, and you'll always know who's riding where tomorrow morning.

Language: Getting By

If you're an English speaker with no Portuguese, you can still participate fully in the community. Many riders — especially younger ones and those with international experience — speak some English. But making even a minimal effort with Portuguese wins enormous goodwill.

Essential trail Portuguese:

- Bora pedalar! — Let's ride!
- Tá tudo bem? — Everything okay?
- Passando! — Coming through!
- Esperando! — Waiting (at a junction for the group)
- Furou! — Flat tire!
- Acabou a água — Out of water
- Que trilha massa! — What an awesome trail!
- Valeu! — Thanks!
- Mais um pedal — One more ride (the rallying cry)

Learn these ten phrases and you'll be communicating on the trail. The rest will come with time.

The Spirit of Pedalada

There's a word that captures everything about Brasília's riding culture: pedalada.

It means, literally, a ride — the act of going out on a bike. But it carries layers of meaning that the English word "ride" doesn't. A pedalada is an event, a social gathering, a shared experience. It's the sunrise seen from the same ridgeline as twenty other riders. It's the post-ride cafezinho (small coffee) that lasts longer than the ride itself. It's the WhatsApp message at 6:00 AM: "Pedalada hoje?" (Ride today?)

It's the knowledge that somewhere in this vast, strange, beautiful city, there are people on bikes who understand exactly why you do this.

That's the community. That's Brasília.

Bora pedalar.

Chapter 12: Events & Races



Full send on a dusty cerrado trail — the adrenaline of race day
in Brasília

There's a moment at the start line of a race that nothing else in life replicates.

You're shoulder to shoulder with a hundred other riders. Some are deadly serious — aero helmets, skinsuit, grim focus. Some are grinning like idiots. Someone is fiddling with their cleat. Someone else is taking a selfie. The countdown starts and your heart rate spikes before you've turned a single pedal.

Then the horn blows and everything is noise and dust and adrenaline.

I entered my first race in Brasília as a joke. A friend dared me. "Just come — it'll be fun." I finished near the back, cramped from kilometer 30, and seriously questioned my life choices at kilometer 40. I swore I'd never race again.

I signed up for the next one the following week.

Racing isn't for everyone. But if there's a competitive bone anywhere in your body — even if it's only competing against yourself — Brasília's event calendar offers something extraordinary. From beginner-friendly fun rides to multi-day expeditions that test the limits of human endurance, the DF punches way above its weight in mountain bike events.

The Big Events

Desafio das Capivaras

When: Typically July

Where: Parque Nacional area / FLONA surrounds

Distances: Multiple categories — typically 10 km (kids/beginner), 35 km (sport), 55+ km (elite)

Difficulty: Moderate to Hard (depending on category)

Vibe: Celebratory, inclusive, community-focused

Named after Brasília's most beloved resident — the capybara — this event is the heart of the DF's racing calendar. It's the race that everyone does, from first-time racers to podium chasers.

The Desafio das Capivaras ("Capybara Challenge") runs through cerrado terrain that showcases the best of Brasília's landscape: red dirt, gallery forest, creek crossings, and the constant gentle undulations that define the Planalto Central. The course changes slightly each year but always features a mix of fire road and singletrack.

What makes Capivaras special isn't the course — it's the atmosphere. This is a celebration of mountain biking culture as much as a race. The start area has a festival vibe: music, food vendors, bike shop tents, mechanic stations. The course is well-marshalled with water stations and mechanical support. And the post-race confraternização (get-together) is legendary — cold beer, churrasco, and stories that get more dramatic with each telling.

For first-time racers, the shorter categories provide a structured, supported introduction to competitive riding. You'll have the energy of a race without the pressure of an elite field. Sign up. You won't regret it.

André's Tip: Registration fills up fast — Capivaras typically sells out weeks before the event. Check social media for registration opening dates and sign up immediately. Also, pick up your race kit (number, timing chip, swag bag) the day before if possible to avoid the morning-of chaos.

BSB500

When: Typically November

Where: Circuit around the DF and surrounding municipalities

Distance: 500 km

Difficulty: Extreme

Vibe: Ultra-endurance, self-supported, mental warfare

Five hundred kilometers. On dirt. Through the cerrado.

BSB500 is not a race for most people. It's a race for people who've done all the other races and thought: "That wasn't enough."

The format is straightforward in concept: riders complete a 500-kilometer route through the countryside surrounding Brasília, navigating by GPS, carrying their own supplies, and managing sleep deprivation, equipment failure, and the psychological warfare of very long distances. Cutoff times are generous but real. Support vehicles provide aid at designated checkpoints, but between checkpoints, you're on your own.

The route crosses every type of terrain the DF has to offer: paved roads, dirt tracks, farm roads, singletrack, river crossings, and sections where the "road" is more of a suggestion than a reality. Day turns to night turns to day again. You learn things about yourself that no shorter event can teach.

I haven't done BSB500. I plan to. It scares me, and that's exactly why I want to do it.

Desafio FLONA

When: Varies (check annual calendar)

Where: FLONA trail system

Distances: Multiple categories — typically 20 km, 35 km, and 50+ km

Difficulty: Moderate to Hard

Vibe: Trail-focused, community-supported, showcase of FLONA

The Desafio FLONA is the home race — the event that uses Brasília's most beloved trail system as its course. If you've been riding FLONA's routes all year, this is where you test yourself on familiar terrain against the clock and other riders.

The course leverages FLONA's signalized routes, linking them into race-specific loops. The shorter categories stay on the more accessible routes (Rotas 3-4 territory), while the longer categories venture into the deeper, more technical terrain of Rotas 5-7.

For riders who've been training on FLONA all season, this race is a benchmark. You know every creek crossing, every climb, every corner. The question is: how fast can you ride them?

XCM Brasília (Cross-Country Marathon)

When: Typically September-October

Where: Various DF locations

Distances: 40 km, 60 km, 80+ km categories

Difficulty: Hard

Vibe: Competitive, fast, fitness-focused

XCM is the classic marathon cross-country format: long distance, timed, with a focus on sustained aerobic fitness. The courses use a mix of Brasília's trail networks, emphasizing speed on dirt roads and technical skill on singletrack sections.

This is the event for riders who train systematically and want to measure their fitness against a competitive field. The longer categories (60-80+ km) are genuinely demanding — expect 3-5 hours of sustained effort.

Sertão Diamante

When: Typically October

Where: Sertão region north of Brasília (see Chapter 10)

Format: Multi-stage event (3-5 days)

Daily distances: 30-100+ km per stage

Difficulty: Advanced to Expert

Vibe: Expedition, adventure, camaraderie in adversity

The Sertão Diamante is not just a race — it's an experience. Over multiple days, riders traverse the diamond mining backcountry north of Brasília, camping, riding, and discovering landscapes that most Brasilienses have never seen.

Each day brings a different stage with different terrain and distances. Support vehicles carry camping gear and supplies between stage points. Riders are responsible for their own hydration and nutrition during stages but can restock at transitions.

The camaraderie at Sertão Diamante is intense — the shared suffering of multi-day expedition riding bonds people in ways that single-day events can't. Riders who've done Sertão Diamante talk about it for years.

Smaller Events & Regular Races

Beyond the marquee events, Brasília has a calendar packed with smaller races, group challenges, and regular competitive events:

Night rides: Several groups organize competitive night rides through FLONA and other trail systems, with riders required to use lights. These are incredible experiences — the cerrado at night is a different world.

Time trials: Informal timed segments on popular routes, tracked via Strava. The competition is virtual but intense. Check the Strava segment leaderboards for FLONA's routes to see the times to beat.

Charity rides: Annual rides that raise money for local causes, usually with a festival atmosphere and family-friendly distances.

Shop-sponsored rides: Local bike shops organize rides and mini-races to build community and showcase products. These are often free and open to all levels.

How to Get Started Racing

Your First Event: A Practical Guide

1. Choose a beginner-friendly event. Desafio das Capivaras (short distance), Desafio FLONA (short distance), or a charity ride. Look for events with 20-30 km categories.

2. Register early. Events sell out. Follow the organizers on social media for registration announcements.

3. Train on the course. If the event is on FLONA trails, ride those trails in training. Familiarity with the terrain is a massive advantage.

4. Prepare your bike. Get a tune-up 1-2 weeks before the event. New tires if needed. Fresh brake pads. Clean drivetrain. Do NOT try new equipment on race day.

5. Pre-ride nutrition. Eat a solid meal 2-3 hours before the start. Nothing new, nothing exotic — eat what you know works. Hydrate well the day before.

6. On race day:

- Arrive at least 1 hour before your start time
- Set up your bike, warm up, check in
- Pin your number on your jersey (safety pins, not tape)
- Line up according to your estimated speed — fast riders front, slower riders back
- Start conservatively — the first 10 minutes of a race are where most people blow up by going out too hard
- Ride YOUR race, not someone else's
- Enjoy it

7. After the race: Eat, drink, recover. Sign up for the next one.

André's Tip: Race-day nerves are real, even for experienced riders. My pre-race routine: arrive early, set up slowly, ride a 10-minute warm-up, eat a banana, use the bathroom (critical — nothing worse than needing a bathroom break at kilometer 15), and take three deep breaths at the start line. The nerves transform into energy the moment the horn sounds.

The Racing Calendar

Brasília's racing calendar loosely follows the seasons:

May-June: Season openers. Shorter events to kick off the dry season. Shakedown races.

July-August: Peak season. Major events including Desafio das Capivaras. Best weather, best trail conditions.

September-October: Late season. XCM and longer-format events. Trail conditions still good but warming up.

November: Season closer. BSB500 for the extreme crowd. Transition to rainy season.

December-April: Off-season for formal events (rain), but informal group rides continue year-round.

Follow local cycling media, Rebas do Cerrado social channels, and bike shop bulletin boards for the most up-to-date calendar. Dates shift annually.

Chapter 13: Brasília Bike Camp & Training



The next generation rides the cerrado — passing the passion
forward

I used to think getting faster meant just riding more. More kilometers, more hours, more suffering. And look — riding a lot does help. But there came a point where I was putting in the miles and not getting better. My cornering was sloppy. My climbs felt like I was fighting the bike instead of flowing with it. I could ride far, but I couldn't ride well.

The turning point was the first time I showed up to a skills clinic. A coach watched me descend a rocky section I'd ridden a hundred times and said, "You're braking with your arms, not your legs." I had no idea what that meant. Twenty minutes later, after he adjusted my body position, I rode the same section two seconds faster and it felt like floating.

That's the thing about mountain biking skills — you don't know what you don't know. And Brasília, thankfully, has a growing ecosystem of coaches, camps, and training programs that can take your riding from "I survive the trail" to "I own the trail."

Skills Clinics in Brasília

Brasília Bike Camp

The Brasília Bike Camp is the gold standard for structured mountain bike instruction in the DF. Founded by riders who got tired of watching people white-knuckle their way down perfectly manageable descents, the camp offers clinics ranging from absolute beginner to advanced racers.

Their format is smart: half-day sessions that focus on one or two core skills rather than trying to cram everything into a weekend. You might spend a Saturday morning doing nothing but cornering — understanding countersteering, outside foot pressure, where your eyes should be (spoiler: not at your front wheel). The following week might be all about climbing efficiency — gear selection, cadence, when to sit versus stand,

and how to read the terrain ahead so you're never caught in the wrong gear on a steep subida (climb).

What I love about the Bike Camp approach is the progression. They don't throw you onto technical terrain before you've nailed the fundamentals. You practice on flat ground. Then gentle slopes. Then moderate trails. Then — only when the movements are becoming automatic — the real stuff.

André's Tip: Don't skip the beginner clinic even if you've been riding for years. I did the "Fundamentals" session after five years of riding and discovered I'd been positioning my feet wrong on descents the entire time. Ego is the enemy of improvement. Show up, shut up, and learn.

Private Coaching

Several certified MTB coaches in Brasília offer one-on-one sessions. This is the fastest way to improve because the feedback is immediate and specific to YOUR habits. A good coach will film you riding, play it back, and show you exactly where you're losing time or wasting energy.

Expect to pay R\$150-300 per hour for private coaching. It sounds steep, but one session with a great coach can fix habits that years of solo riding never will.

Group Rides as Training

Don't underestimate the training value of Brasília's regular group rides. Riding with people who are faster than you is the best free coaching available. You watch their lines, their body position, their braking points. You learn by osmosis.

The trick is finding a group that's slightly above your level — enough to push you, not so much that you're gasping at the back and learning nothing except what your lungs look like when they're trying to escape your chest.

Check with Rebas do Cerrado for organized group rides sorted by pace and skill level. The community is genuinely welcoming to riders who want to improve. Just show up, be honest about your level, and be ready to work.

How to Level Up Your Riding

The Five Pillars of MTB Skill

After years of riding, coaching conversations, and more crashes than I care to admit, I've come to believe mountain biking skill breaks down into five core areas:

1. Body Position

Everything starts here. Heels dropped, elbows bent, hips back on descents, chest over the bars on climbs. Your body is the suspension system that your actual suspension relies on. Get this wrong and no amount of fitness will save you.

2. Vision

Look where you want to go, not where you don't. This sounds like fortune-cookie advice, but it's literally the most important skill in mountain biking. Your bike follows your eyes. Look at the rock you want to avoid? You'll hit it. Look at the clean line beside it? You'll flow right through.

3. Braking

Most riders brake too much, too late, in the wrong places. Learn to brake before the obstacle, not during. Use both brakes, with emphasis

on the rear for control. And here's the counterintuitive truth: better braking means you can actually go faster, because you brake later and with more confidence.

4. Cornering

The cerrado trails of Brasília are full of sweeping curves through red dirt — perfect for learning. Outside foot down, inside knee out, weight on the outside pedal, look through the exit. Practice this on gentle corners until it's muscle memory, then take it to the berms.

5. Climbing Efficiency

Brasília's gentle undulations are deceptive — they add up. Learning to spin efficiently in the right gear, using momentum, and knowing when to attack versus when to conserve transforms those morrinhos (little hills) from energy drains into rhythm sections.

André's Tip: Pick ONE skill per month and focus on it obsessively. January is cornering month? Every ride, every corner, you're thinking about technique. By month's end, it's automatic. Then move to the next skill. Trying to improve everything at once means improving nothing.

Strength & Conditioning for Mountain Biking

Off the Bike Matters

Here's a truth that took me too long to accept: what you do OFF the bike matters as much as what you do ON it. Especially as you get older. Especially in Brasília's heat.

Mountain biking demands a specific kind of fitness — a blend of aerobic endurance, explosive power, core stability, and flexibility that no single exercise provides. You need a program.

The MTB Strength Foundation

Core Work (3x per week, 15-20 minutes)

Your core is your platform. Everything — steering, absorbing impacts, climbing, sprinting — transfers through your core. If it's weak, energy leaks everywhere.

- Planks (front and side) — build to 60 seconds each
- Dead bugs — 3 sets of 10 per side
- Russian twists with a medicine ball — 3 sets of 15
- Pallof press — 3 sets of 10 per side

Leg Strength (2x per week)

You pedal with your legs, yes. But you also absorb impacts, stabilize in corners, and support your body weight on descents with your legs. Build them.

- Squats — 3 sets of 8-12
- Romanian deadlifts — 3 sets of 8-10
- Bulgarian split squats — 3 sets of 8 per leg
- Calf raises — 3 sets of 15

Upper Body (2x per week)

Your arms and shoulders absorb every root, rock, and rut. Neglect them and your hands go numb thirty minutes into a ride, your shoulders ache, and your bike control suffers.

- Push-ups — 3 sets of 12-15
- Rows (dumbbell or band) — 3 sets of 10
- Shoulder press — 3 sets of 10

- Farmer carries — 3 sets of 30-meter walks

André's Tip: I do my core work first thing in the morning before the Brasília heat kicks in — 15 minutes on the living room floor with coffee brewing. Make it a habit, not a heroic effort. Consistency beats intensity every single time.

Flexibility & Mobility

Brasília riders have a secret enemy: the car. Most of us drive to trailheads, sit at desks during the week, and then wonder why our hips are tight and our lower backs hurt on the bike.

Stretch after every ride. Not before — after. Focus on:

- Hip flexors (the MTB rider's nemesis)
- Hamstrings
- Lower back
- Shoulders and neck
- Wrists and forearms

Ten minutes of post-ride stretching does more for your riding longevity than any supplement or fancy gear.

Heat Training

Brasília's dry season is paradise for trail conditions but brutal for human bodies. Temperatures routinely hit 30-35°C with humidity below 20%. Your body loses water faster than you realize, and dehydration destroys performance before you even feel thirsty.

Heat acclimatization is real training:

- **Ride early or late.** The 6:00-9:00 AM and 4:00-6:30 PM windows are your friends.
- **Hydrate before you ride.** If your pee isn't clear before you clip in, you're already behind.
- **Electrolytes, not just water.** Sweat takes salt with it. Replace it. Brazilian pharmacies sell sais de reidratação (rehydration salts) cheaply.
- **Build up gradually.** Don't do your first long ride of the dry season at noon. Acclimate over 2-3 weeks with progressively longer and hotter rides.

André's Training Philosophy

I'm not a professional athlete. I'm a guy who loves riding bikes, runs a business, has a life, and wants to be riding trails when he's 70. My training philosophy reflects that.

Ride for joy first, performance second. The moment training becomes a chore, something is wrong. Every ride should have a moment where you think, "This is why I do this." If it doesn't, change something.

Consistency over heroics. Three 90-minute rides per week beats one epic 6-hour weekend suffer-fest. Your body adapts to regular stimulus, not occasional punishment.

Listen to your body in the heat. Brasília's climate is unforgiving. There's no shame in cutting a ride short when the seca (dry season) is at its peak and your head is pounding. Live to ride another day.

Train your weaknesses, race your strengths. Hate climbing? That's your training focus. Love descending? Save that for race day. The skills you avoid are the ones holding you back.

Recovery is training. Sleep. Eat well. Stretch. Take rest days. The actual fitness gains happen while you're NOT riding — your body needs time to rebuild stronger. In Brasília's heat, this goes double.

André's Tip: Keep a simple training log. Nothing fancy — just date, route, distance, how you felt (1-5 scale), and one thing you learned or noticed. After a few months, the patterns become obvious: when you ride best, what wrecks you, how rest affects performance. Data beats guessing.

Finding Your Flow

There's a state that experienced riders talk about — the Japanese call it *mushin*, "no mind." You're descending a trail you know well, and suddenly you're not thinking anymore. Your body reacts, your bike flows, obstacles appear and disappear beneath your wheels without conscious decision. Time distorts. The world shrinks to the trail ahead and the rhythm of your breath.

You can't force flow. But you can create the conditions for it: ride trails you know well, at a pace that challenges but doesn't overwhelm, with skills sharp enough that technique is automatic.

That state — that feeling of being completely present, completely alive, completely in motion — is the real reason we train. Not for the Strava times. Not for the podium. For those seconds on the trail where everything else disappears and it's just you and the cerrado and the sound of dirt under your tires.

Train for that.

Part V: The Journey

Chapter 14: Taking It to the Next Level



The Digital TV Tower rises over Brasília — a landmark for every
rider navigating the Planalto Central

We're near the end of this book, and I want to be honest with you.

When I started writing, I thought I was making a trail guide. Here are the routes, here's the gear, here's how not to die. Practical stuff. But somewhere around Chapter 5, I realized this book is really about something else. It's about falling in love with a place through the act of riding through it. It's about the cerrado revealing itself one trail at a time — a waterfall you didn't know existed, a sunset that stops you mid-pedal, a capybara giving you the most unimpressed look any animal has ever given a human.

Brasília's mountain biking scene is young. It's growing fast. And you're part of it now.

This final chapter is about everything else — the resources, the shops, the tools, the competitions, and the future of this thing we love. Consider it your launch pad.

Competitions: Getting Into Racing

If Chapter 12 got you curious about racing but you're still hovering over the registration button, let me push you.

How to Enter Your First Competition

Step 1: Pick the right event.

Start small. A 20-30 km fun ride or the beginner category of an established event like the Desafio das Capivaras. Don't debut at BSB500. Please.

Step 2: Register online.

Most Brasília events use platforms like Ticket Sports (ticketsports.com.br) or Sympla for registration. Follow the event

organizer's Instagram — that's where registration links drop first, and popular events sell out in hours.

Step 3: Understand the categories.

Brazilian MTB events typically divide by age and gender:

- Sub-30, Master A (30-39), Master B (40-49), Master C (50+)
- Feminino (Women's) and Masculino (Men's)
- Iniciante (Beginner), Sport, Elite

Pick the category that matches your level honestly. There's no shame in starting in Iniciante. There IS shame in starting in Elite and walking your bike up the first climb while 55-year-olds fly past you. Ask me how I know.

Step 4: Get your license (for serious racing).

For casual events, you just register and show up. For sanctioned races (affiliated with the Confederação Brasileira de Ciclismo — CBC), you'll need a racing license. Your local bike shop or cycling club can guide you through the process. It involves a medical certificate (atestado médico) and a modest annual fee.

Step 5: Show up and have fun.

Seriously. Your first race is about finishing, not winning. Soak it in.

André's Tip: Your first race will feel twice as hard as your hardest training ride. That's normal — adrenaline makes you start too fast, nerves burn extra energy, and the unfamiliar course keeps you on edge. Expect it, accept it, and pace yourself. The fun starts at kilometer 10 when the nerves wear off.

The Competitive Pathway

For riders who catch the racing bug, Brasília offers a genuine competitive pathway:

1. **Fun rides and charity events** → Learn what racing feels like
2. **Local events (Capivaras, Desafio FLONA)** → Compete in structured categories
3. **Regional XCM races** → Test yourself against a wider field
4. **State and national championships** → Represent the DF
5. **Ultra-endurance (BSB500, Sertão Diamante)** → A different kind of challenge entirely

The DF has produced national-level riders. The talent is here. The trails are here. The question is whether you want it badly enough.

Best Bike Shops in Brasília

A great bike shop isn't just a store — it's a community hub, a repair lifeline, and often the first place you hear about a new trail or upcoming event. Brasília has several outstanding shops that serve the MTB community.

What to Look For

Not all bike shops are created equal. For mountain bikers in Brasília, prioritize shops that:

- **Stock MTB-specific parts.** Road bike shops sometimes carry mountain bike gear as an afterthought. You want a shop where the staff rides dirt.

- **Have skilled mechanics.** Suspension service, tubeless setup, brake bleeding — these require specific knowledge. Ask who works on their forks and shocks.
- **Know the local trails.** The best shops have staff who ride the trails you ride. They know which tires work on Brasília's red clay, which brake pads survive the dust, which chain lube handles the seca.
- **Offer fitting services.** A proper bike fit — adjusting saddle height, reach, handlebar position — transforms comfort and performance. Several Brasília shops now offer professional fitting.

Shop Culture

Brazilian bike shop culture is wonderfully social. It's normal to hang out, drink a cafezinho (small coffee), and talk riding for an hour without buying anything. Shops often sponsor group rides, host race registration, and serve as informal bulletin boards for the community.

Build a relationship with your local shop. When your derailleur explodes on a Saturday afternoon before a Sunday race, that relationship is worth its weight in titanium.

André's Tip: Support your local bike shop, even when online prices are lower. That shop sponsors local races, employs mechanics who'll fix your bike at 5 PM on a Friday, and keeps the community alive. The R\$20-50 you "save" buying online costs the ecosystem that makes your riding life possible.

Online Resources, Apps & Digital Tools

Strava

If you ride in Brasília and you're not on Strava, do you even ride?

Strava is the social network for cyclists, and Brasília's MTB community is deeply embedded in it. Beyond tracking your rides, Strava lets you:

- **Discover routes** other riders have logged in the DF
- **Compare segment times** on popular trails (the FLONA segments are fiercely competitive)
- **Join clubs** like Rebas do Cerrado's Strava group
- **Track your fitness** over time with training load analysis

The free version is solid. The paid version (Strava Summit) adds route planning, live segments, and deeper analytics — worth it if you're training seriously.

Wikiloc

For trail discovery, Wikiloc is indispensable. This platform hosts thousands of GPS tracks uploaded by riders across the DF, complete with elevation profiles, difficulty ratings, photos, and comments.

Planning a ride on a trail you've never done? Search Wikiloc for the trail name, download the GPS track to your phone or bike computer, and follow it. The community-sourced data is remarkably accurate and constantly updated.

Pro move: After your ride, upload YOUR track with photos and notes. Pay it forward for the next rider.

Rebas do Cerrado

Rebas do Cerrado deserves its own section because they're more than an app or a website — they're the backbone of organized mountain biking in Brasília.

At **pedal.rebas.com.br**, you'll find:

- Detailed trail guides with maps, elevation profiles, and difficulty ratings
- Event calendar for the DF and surrounding regions
- Community forums and ride reports
- Trail condition updates (critical during the transition between dry and rainy seasons)

Follow them on Instagram and WhatsApp groups for real-time trail conditions and ride announcements. If there's one resource you bookmark from this entire book, make it Rebas.

Other Useful Apps

- **Komoot** — Route planning with MTB-specific trail data
- **TrailForks** — Growing database of Brazilian trails with condition reports
- **Google Maps (Satellite view)** — Surprisingly useful for spotting unmarked trails and planning routes through the cerrado
- **WhatsApp** — Not technically a cycling app, but Brasília's MTB community runs on WhatsApp groups. Join them. That's where the real-time intelligence lives.

André's Tip: Create a dedicated "MTB Brasília" folder on your phone with Strava, Wikiloc, WhatsApp (for group ride coordination), and a basic first-aid guide. Download trail maps

offline before you ride — cell signal in the cerrado is unreliable at best and nonexistent at worst.

The Future of MTB in Brasília

I moved back to Brasília after sixteen years in the United States. When I left, mountain biking here was a handful of guys on heavy bikes riding dirt roads. When I came back, I found a fully formed ecosystem — 400 kilometers of mapped trails, organized events, dedicated shops, coaching programs, and a community that rivals anything I saw in the States.

The growth has been explosive, and it's not slowing down.

What's Coming

Trail infrastructure is expanding. The Caminhos do Planalto Central project is building a 400-kilometer network of trails connecting the entire DF — three arcs of linked routes that will make Brasília one of the premier trail destinations in South America. This isn't a dream; it's under active development.

The 136-kilometer circuit is growing. The Trilha União, connecting FLONA to Serrinha do Paranoá, is already the largest MTB circuit in Brazil. Plans to extend and improve this network are ongoing.

International attention is building. As Brazil's adventure tourism sector grows, Brasília's unique combination of accessible trails, dramatic landscapes, and modern infrastructure is attracting international riders. The cerrado biome — one of the world's great biodiversity hotspots — is a draw that no other MTB destination can replicate.

Women's participation is surging. The feminino categories at local events are growing faster than any other segment. Women-specific

clinics, rides, and communities are flourishing. This is transforming the culture in the best possible way.

E-bikes are arriving. Love them or hate them, electric mountain bikes are opening the trails to riders who couldn't access them before — older riders, riders with injuries, riders who want to extend their range. Brasília's relatively gentle terrain is perfect for e-MTB exploration.

The Challenges Ahead

Growth brings challenges. Trail access negotiations with land managers, environmental protection of the cerrado, sustainable trail building, managing user conflicts between hikers, bikers, and equestrians — these are real issues that the community needs to address thoughtfully.

The Brasília MTB community has a responsibility to be stewards of the cerrado, not just consumers of it. Ride responsibly. Stay on marked trails. Carry out your trash. Support organizations like Rebas do Cerrado that work on trail maintenance and access. The trails we enjoy today exist because someone fought for them. The trails our kids will ride depend on how we treat them now.

A Final Word

I want to tell you one more story.

A few months into writing this book, I was riding alone on a trail near Fercal — my home turf, a route I know by heart. It was late afternoon, the golden hour that Brasília does better than anywhere on Earth. The ipê amarelo trees were in bloom, painting the cerrado in splashes of yellow. I came around a bend and startled a pair of seriemas (red-legged birds) who shrieked indignantly and stalked away like offended aristocrats.

I stopped. Straddled my bike. Took off my helmet. Just breathed.

The cerrado hummed with life. The sky was turning orange and pink and purple. The red dirt on my legs and arms was drying in the warm breeze. My heart rate was still elevated from the last climb. I was completely, perfectly happy.

That's what this book is really about. Not gear ratios and tire pressure and race registration. Those things matter — they're the scaffolding. But the building itself? It's this. These moments. This landscape. This feeling of being alive and in motion through a place that rewards your attention at every turn.

Brasília isn't on most people's list of dream mountain biking destinations. It should be. And now that you've read this book, you know why.

So clip in. Point your wheel at the red dirt. And go find your own golden hour on the trails of the Planalto Central.

I'll see you out there.

Bora pedalar. Let's ride.

André's Tip: One last one. The best ride you'll ever do in Brasília isn't in this book. It's the one you discover yourself — the unmarked trail that a local tells you about over a beer, the wrong turn that leads somewhere magical, the random Wednesday evening when the light is perfect and the trail is empty and everything clicks. Stay curious. Keep exploring. The cerrado always has one more secret.



Brasília's legendary golden sunset over Lago Paranoá — the
cerrado stretching to the horizon

Back Matter

Acknowledgments

No book is a solo ride.

First, to the **Brasília mountain biking community** — the riders, trail builders, event organizers, and weekend warriors who have turned the cerrado into one of Brazil's great cycling destinations. You built this scene with sweat, passion, and an unreasonable number of WhatsApp messages. This book exists because of you.

To **Rebas do Cerrado** — for mapping the trails, organizing the rides, maintaining the routes, and being the connective tissue of MTB in the DF. What you do for this community is immeasurable.

To the **trail builders and maintainers** — the people who show up with shovels and machetes to clear routes, mark signage, and keep the trails rideable through seasons wet and dry. You are the unsung heroes.

To the **bike shops of Brasília** — for fixing our bikes at impossible hours, sponsoring events, and being the living rooms of our community.

To my **family** — for understanding when I disappear at dawn on a Saturday and return covered in red dirt, grinning like an idiot. For tolerating the bikes in the living room, the gear in the garage, and the endless trail stories at dinner. Your patience is my greatest luxury.

To **Brasília itself** — the city that surprised me. I left Brazil as a young man and came back sixteen years later to discover that the place I'd overlooked had become the place I love most. The cerrado earned my devotion one trail at a time.

And to you, the reader — for picking up this book, for being curious about this strange and beautiful city, and for wanting to explore it on two wheels. I hope these pages serve you well on the trail.

Valeu, galera. Thank you, everyone.

About the Author



The view from Lago Paranoá — where every ride in Brasília feels
like coming home

André Raw is a Brazilian cyclist, entrepreneur, and proud brasiliense by choice. Born in Brazil, he spent sixteen years living in the United States — eight in Massachusetts and eight in Florida — before returning to Brasília, where he now lives in Grande Colorado, in the Fercal region, at the doorstep of some of the DF's best trails.

André rides year-round, logging routes from 17 to 46+ kilometers through the cerrado, FLONA, and the backcountry surrounding Brasília. He is an active member of the local MTB community, a regular at group rides and events, and an advocate for trail access and environmental stewardship.

When he's not on a bike, André runs a catering business and spends too much time arguing about tire pressure on the internet.

Mountain Biking in Brasília: The Ultimate Guide is his first book — born from a simple frustration that no English-language resource existed for the incredible riding in the DF, and a deep love for the landscape and community that make it special.

Follow André's rides on Strava and connect on Instagram for trail updates, ride reports, and the occasional sunset photo that will make you book a flight to Brasília.

Trail Quick Reference

Trail	Distance	Difficulty	Highlights
FLONA Rota 1	5 km	Beginner	Gentle introduction, well-signalized
FLONA Rota 2	12 km	Beginner	Creek crossings, cerrado scenery
FLONA Rota 3	18 km	Intermediate	Gallery forest, diverse terrain
FLONA Rota 4	25 km	Intermediate	Elevation gains, great views
FLONA Rota 5	32 km	Advanced	Technical singletrack, remote sections
FLONA Rota 6	38 km	Advanced	Full-day commitment, waterfall access
FLONA Rota 7	44 km	Expert	The ultimate FLONA challenge
Córrego do Ouro	48 km	Difficult	980m elevation, starts at CIPLAN/Fercal
Catingueiro	27 km	Moderate	Resistance training, Vila Boa Vista start
Trilha 3 Riachos	~30 km	Challenging	Cerrado deep cuts, Sobradinho II
Trilha União	45 km	Advanced	Connects FLONA to Serrinha do Paranoá
Trilha Olaria	41 km	Moderate	Fazenda Xanguí, Cachoeira Três Quedas

Trail	Distance	Difficulty	Highlights
Trilha Pé D'Serra	100 km	Expert	Epic loop around Brazlândia
Parque Nacional trails	7-10 km	Intermediate-Advanced	Wildlife, iconic landscapes

Distances and difficulties are approximate. Trail conditions vary by season. Always check current conditions before riding.



Useful Portuguese Phrases for the Trail

Greetings & Basics

- Bora pedalar! — Let's ride!
- E aí, beleza? — Hey, how's it going?
- Valeu! — Thanks! (casual)
- Obrigado / Obrigada — Thank you (male/female speaker)
- Com licença — Excuse me (passing someone)
- Bom pedal! — Have a good ride!

On the Trail

- Trilha — Trail
- Subida — Climb / uphill
- Descida — Descent / downhill
- Morrinho — Small hill
- Atoleiro — Mud pit
- Cachoeira — Waterfall
- Córrego / Riacho — Stream / creek
- Ponte — Bridge
- Porteira — Farm gate
- Curva — Turn / corner

Emergencies & Help

- Preciso de ajuda — I need help
- Estou perdido/a — I'm lost
- Tem água? — Do you have water?
- Furou o pneu — I got a flat tire
- Quebrou a corrente — My chain broke

- Cadê a saída? — Where's the exit?

At the Bike Shop

- Câmara de ar — Inner tube
- Pneu — Tire
- Freio — Brake
- Câmbio — Derailleur
- Corrente — Chain
- Suspensão — Suspension fork
- Revisão — Tune-up / service

Post-Ride

- Cerveja gelada, por favor — Cold beer, please
 - Que trilha incrível! — What an amazing trail!
 - Tô destruído/a — I'm wrecked (exhausted)
 - Confraternização — Get-together / celebration
 - Churrasco — Barbecue
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Resources & Links

Trail Information

- Rebas do Cerrado — pedal.rebas.com.br
- Wikiloc (search "Brasília MTB") — wikiloc.com
- Caminhos do Planalto Central — caminhosdoplanaltocentral.com.br
- FLONA de Brasília (official) — gov.br/icmbio

Apps

- Strava — strava.com
- Wikiloc — wikiloc.com
- Komoot — komoot.com
- TrailForks — trailforks.com

Events

- Desafio das Capivaras — follow on Instagram for annual updates
- BSB500 — bsb500.com.br
- Ticket Sports (event registration) — ticketsports.com.br

Community

- Rebas do Cerrado (Instagram & WhatsApp groups)
- Brasília MTB groups on Facebook and WhatsApp
- Local bike shop bulletin boards and social media

Maps & Navigation

- Wikiloc GPS tracks for all major DF trails
- Google Maps satellite view for route planning
- Fercal Trail Guide: Trilhando o Caminho da Beleza e do Turismo Local (Instituto Urucuia, 2025)

Emergency

- SAMU (ambulance): 192
 - Bombeiros (fire/rescue): 193
 - ICMBio (park emergencies): check local postings at trailheads
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